



General Assembly

Seventy-ninth session

Official Records

9th plenary meeting

Wednesday, 25 September 2024, 9 a.m.

New York

President: Mr. Yang (Cameroon)

In the absence of the President, Ms. Botchwey (Ghana), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The meeting was called to order at 9 a.m.

Address by Mr. Khurelsukh Ukhnaa, President of Mongolia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of Mongolia.

Mr. Khurelsukh Ukhnaa, President of Mongolia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Khurelsukh Ukhnaa, President of Mongolia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Ukhnaa (*spoke in Mongolian; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): At the outset, I would like to extend my heartfelt congratulations to His Excellency Mr. Philémon Yang, President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session, and to wish him every success in his important work during this session.

Every time I participate in the General Assembly, I find great pleasure in observing the sculpture entitled *Consciousness*, created by a renowned Mongolian artist and located in the gardens at United Nations Headquarters. It inspires deep contemplation, reminding us of our responsibilities, awareness and dignity in the context of humankind's history and our obligations to future generations. That profoundly meaningful work is a symbol of the historic moment when countries around the world embraced the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Paris Agreement on Climate Change. When I visited it this year the monument stood solemnly, as though urging us to reflect on the goals and commitments we have made for future generations.

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Unfortunately, as we approach the moment when we must assess the implementation of those documents, we can see that our efforts and the progress that we have made are insufficient. For instance, although we are halfway through the timeline for the 2030 Agenda, progress on nearly half of all targets of the Sustainable Development Goals remains inadequate, with 35 per cent showing stagnation. In response, Secretary-General António Guterres initiated the Summit of the Future, with a view to reassessing our realities, revitalizing our commitments and amplifying our collective efforts. At the Summit, which was held just days ago (see A/79/PV.3), we engaged in discussions on policies, objectives and avenues for cooperation concerning sustainable development, science, technology, innovation, youth and the transformation of governance. I am pleased to note that Mongolia actively participated in the negotiation processes for the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), the Declaration on Future Generations and the Global Digital Compact, all of which were discussed and adopted at the Summit. The countries of the world, including our own, must work diligently and cooperate to implement the actions proposed. I am pleased to see that Heads of State and Government and their representatives have wholeheartedly supported those commitments and actions, voicing their positions from this very rostrum.

Our lives are rapidly evolving and becoming interdependent in this age of technological progress and digital advances. However, tensions, armed conflicts and wars continue to escalate in many parts of the world, fuelled by geopolitical tensions that are the result of prejudice, extreme ideologies, mistrust, misunderstanding and disrespect. Mongolia believes that strengthening multilateral cooperation based on international law and the Charter of the United Nations is essential to ensuring international peace and security. Dialogue, mutual understanding and trust are the foundations of sustainable and peaceful coexistence. In order to sustain peace, combat climate change, protect public health, reduce economic inequality and ensure justice, the international community must seek the best possible solutions and foster innovative cooperation in addressing the evolving dynamics of our era.

Presidential and parliamentary elections took place in more than 60 countries this year, with nearly half of the world's population exercising their right to vote, making it a year of significant choices. In Mongolia we too held parliamentary elections, and I would like to highlight that both domestic and foreign observers, as well as international organizations, have commended the successful conduct of our elections within the legal framework. Mongolia has always consistently sought to contribute to the international community's efforts to promote peace and security and sustainable development. In that regard, we have established diplomatic relations with all States Members of the United Nations and are dedicated to strengthening and developing friendly relations and cooperation with all countries around the world. As a nation that consistently pursues a peaceful, open, independent and multi-pillar foreign policy, Mongolia respects the pluralism inherent in the diverse histories, cultures, civilizations, religions, national interests and development paths of countries around the world. We strive to develop international relations based on multi-pillar principles.

My country therefore works to uphold the principles of the Charter of the United Nations, particularly the commitment to refraining from using force to attack the territorial integrity or political independence of any State. In addressing disagreements and conflicts, we call on countries and nations around the world to prioritize diplomatic dialogue over confrontation, promote unity over hostility and pursue collective goals rather than divisiveness so that we can consistently cooperate in strengthening international peace and security.

We Mongols have a rich history of valuing and seeking amicable solutions through dialogue. For centuries the great Mongol empire used political and diplomatic

means to engage in its relations with neighbouring, distant, allied and adversarial nations. That included sending and receiving envoys and ambassadors, concluding agreements, fostering friendships and conducting negotiations — practices that remain cornerstones of Mongolia's current foreign policy. The Gerege serves as historical evidence of that legacy. It represents the origins of credentials given to envoys — like modern diplomatic passports — and has been used by Mongols since the thirteenth century in their relations with other nations. The Gerege is displayed as a historic artefact at United Nations Headquarters, and in 2000, the late former Secretary-General Kofi Annan remarked that the Gerege was an invaluable heritage gifted by Mongols to the international community, emphasizing that we have a lot to learn from the wisdom of our Mongolian ancestors.

The principle of maintaining peace and harmonious coexistence championed by our ancestors reflects the progressive ideals that underpin our current collective efforts to sustain peace and stability. Today humankind is concerned about the deepening global geopolitical tensions that are igniting the fires of war and heightening the nuclear threat. The collective efforts of countries around the world to promote non-proliferation, disarmament and the total elimination of nuclear weapons, as well as the expansion of nuclear-weapon-free zones, must not be overlooked. Mongolia has made significant contributions to the elimination of nuclear threats by having its nuclear-weapon-free status recognized at the international level. We reaffirm our commitment to continuing to pursue and support nuclear-weapon-free policies and initiatives. Mongolia calls on all countries to collaborate in ensuring peace and stability, particularly where creating a world free from nuclear threats is concerned, and we propose convening a special gathering on the issue within the framework of the United Nations.

Mongolia deeply appreciates the role played by United Nations peacekeepers — the Blue Helmets — who serve tirelessly and make significant contributions to international peace and security.

Owing to various factors, such as international terrorism, brutal acts of extremism and the growing number of refugees, the Blue Helmets are confronted with increasingly complex tasks under more challenging conditions. We must not forget that more than 4,370 United Nations peacekeepers, including military, police and civilian personnel, have lost their lives in the line of duty. Although Mongolia has a relatively small population, over the past 20 years, more than 20,000 peacekeepers have been deployed to hotspots around the world to contribute to the peace and security of humankind. In particular, in alignment with the woman and peace and security agenda of the Security Council, we aim to increase women's participation in United Nations peacekeeping operations. Currently, female officers account for 11 per cent of our peacekeepers. To ensure the competence of our peacekeepers, it is crucial to improve their psychological well-being. Therefore, Mongolia initiated and developed a pilot project for supporting peacekeepers and their families, which was submitted to the United Nations Department of Peace Operations.

In recent years, the rapid development of information and communications technologies has had a significant impact on the daily life of people and is seen as a factor that may fundamentally reshape the development of civilization in the future. In that connection, intensive discussions on information and communications technologies and artificial intelligence have arisen in international forums, and the recently adopted Global Digital Compact is a timely and essential step. Our country aims to keep pace with the development of information technology, placing great importance on United Nations resolutions, documents and other international legal frameworks related to that issue and keenly participating in their discussions. In March, the General Assembly adopted its first-ever resolution calling on Member

States to ensure the reliability and security of artificial intelligence (resolution 78/265), in a significant step forward.

In order to accelerate the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals, countries around the world are focusing on policies that promote economic diversification, energy and digital transitions, reduce the negative impacts of climate change, enhance adaptive capacity and increase access to essential social services, particularly in education and health, while also prioritizing employment and food security. On the other hand, global debt accumulation has reached unprecedented levels, with debt service payments in developing countries exceeding the amounts borrowed, further constraining the budgetary space needed to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals. Mongolia fully supports the international community's efforts to not only ensure that sustainability, but also to fundamentally reform the international financial architecture under the initiative outlined in the Secretary-General's report, *Our Common Agenda* (A/75/982).

In the early years of the twenty-first century, ideological conflicts that divided the world became history, while traditional military threats receded and such non-traditional threats as climate change, pandemics, terrorism, cybercrime and refugees gained increasing attention. However, that situation has changed drastically in recent years, with traditional threats resurfacing and negatively affecting international security and sustainable development. In other words, the overlap and expanding scope of traditional and non-traditional threats requires countries around the world to pay special attention and strengthen their collaborative efforts. In particular, global warming and climate change have transcended natural and economic boundaries, exacerbating sensitive social issues and disputes over resources and triggering migration, which brings with it numerous direct and indirect dangerous and risks. If this situation continues, humankind will face not only a choice between development or stagnation, but rather a choice between existence and nonexistence. Therefore, we must carefully assess the situation, recognize the need for smart solutions based on the advancements of our era and the implementation of new technologies and share good practices, while collaborating to overcome challenges posed by climate change.

As descendants of nomads, we Mongols have preserved and honoured our unique cultural heritage and traditions to this day. The origin of our nomadic civilization is, in fact, the philosophy of green development, which emphasizes caring for and protecting nature while responsibly utilizing its benefits. That indicates that we have substantial traditional wisdom and initiatives regarding the future of green development. Thus, in line with the Sustainable Development Goals and its Vision 2050 long-term development policy, Mongolia has successfully been implementing national movements and programmes such as on building, trees, food security and safety, Healthy Mongolia and Digital Mongolia. Those initiatives represent our contributions at both the international and regional levels to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals. I am also pleased to announce that Mongolia is actively working to implement the resolution adopted by the General Assembly declaring 2026 the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists (resolution 76/253). Furthermore, we are also preparing to host the seventeenth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification in Those Countries Experiencing Serious Drought and/or Desertification, Particularly in Africa, in Ulaanbaatar in 2026. I am confident that the international community and Member States will support and collaborate with us in those efforts.

As a landlocked country, with its unique location on the Central Asian plateau and its extreme weather conditions, Mongolia has consistently paid particular attention to the issues of countries in similar special situations. We have already collaborated with them to safeguard our interests and make tangible contributions

to amplifying our voices on the global stage. Mongolia and Austria co-chaired the Preparatory Committee for the third United Nations Conference on Landlocked Developing Countries for 2023–2024 and successfully facilitated discussions on the draft outcome document among Member States. We are pleased that the draft programme of action to be adopted at the upcoming conference in Botswana in December includes innovative content outlining specific goals and measures to guide the development of landlocked developing countries (LLDCs) over the next decade. Therefore, we urge all LLDCs, transit countries and all States Members of the United Nations and development partners to engage at the highest level at the third Conference on LLDCs and to contribute creatively to discussions for the successful implementation of the programme of action.

At the fourth World Conference on Women, held in Beijing in 1995, it was proclaimed that women's rights are human rights and human rights are women's rights, setting forth the significant goal of eliminating barriers to gender equality on the global stage. We Mongols have a time-honoured culture and tradition of honouring and respecting women, with a history of Mongol queens and women who played crucial roles in governance and social affairs throughout our nation's history. That rich traditional and cultural heritage have continued to advance Mongolia's position as one of the leaders in promoting gender equality in Asia. In its first constitution, Mongolia became the first country in Asia to guarantee equal rights for women, including the right to vote and the right to be elected.

This year, we celebrate the centennial of the establishment of the National Organization for Women, the Mongolian women's federation. As we approach that historic anniversary in 2023, we have implemented legal policy reform designed to enhance women's participation at both the social and the political decision-making levels. As a result, in the recent parliamentary election, 25.4 per cent of elected members were women, exceeding the average rate of 21.2 per cent in Asia. Moreover, in August, our country successfully hosted the World Women's Forum in Ulaanbaatar, under the theme "Towards a Green Future", in collaboration with the United Nations. That forum brought together women leaders from Governments and international organizations and influential representatives from diverse sectors, social, economic and cultural across four continents. They proposed numerous creative initiatives to enhance the role of women and contribute to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals, including in the areas of economics, environment, climate change, food security, education, sports, culture and the arts. I am pleased to say that the Ulaanbaatar Declaration: Towards a Sustainable Future was adopted as the Forum's outcome document. Building on the momentum of the World Women's Forum, Mongolia will continue to actively promote gender equality and the empowerment of women.

The General Assembly is the most important and honourable rostrum we have for amplifying voices, ideas and aspirations in favour of international peace and security and the welfare and development of humankind. Mongolia has consistently supported the efforts of Member States to reform the Security Council so that it can become a more equitable, accessible, transparent, effective, democratic and responsible system. We also strongly advocate for further strengthening the central coordinating role of the United Nations in global affairs. Our country believes that any international challenges and misunderstandings should be addressed through mutual understanding, trust, respect and dialogue and be resolved within the framework of international legal norms. I therefore call on the Heads of State and Government and other representatives here to demonstrate exceptional leadership and make meaningful contributions to strengthening trust, mutual respect and cooperation among the nations of the world in the crucial pursuit of global peace, security, sustainable development and the well-being of humankind. May the eternal blue sky bless us with peace throughout the world.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Mongolia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Khurelsukh Ukhnaa, President of Mongolia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Wavel Ramkalawan, President of the Republic of Seychelles

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Seychelles.

Mr. Wavel Ramkalawan, President of the Republic of Seychelles, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Wavel Ramkalawani, President of the Seychelles, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Ramkalawan: I would first of all like to extend my congratulations to Ambassador Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at this seventy-ninth session. I also want to thank Ambassador Francis for his diligent leadership during the seventy-eighth session.

As the highest representatives of the peoples of the world, we meet here every year in this institution, which promises to deliver peace, progress and prosperity for all. We must be frank — frank in our assessment of what we are doing for the people whom we represent and whose interests we serve. When it comes to my people of the Seychelles, we must be critical of our approach to the challenges of today and plan for the challenges of tomorrow.

The world is less secure than it was even just a year ago. While at the time we hoped that existing conflicts could be resolved, we now find ourselves in a situation that is more tense and precarious. Flames stoked by competition and distrust threaten to engulf those who have no part in those conflicts, leaving us in the grip of a fearful atmosphere of instability, which is exacerbated by the worry that warfare could spread. We are in danger of losing sight of the values that bring us together, that transcend borders and cultures and that are understood in all languages and present in all ideologies. We must revert to our foundational principles of dialogue and cooperation. Without a stable foundation, we cannot build our vision of a peaceful, prosperous and sustainable world. Our focus has been diverted from the challenges requiring our urgent and undivided attention — challenges affecting the core of people's lives and requiring solutions with people at their centre, such as addressing the climate crisis, ending poverty and hunger and ensuring that all have the indisputable right to a decent and dignified life. Our people have entrusted us with the task of working together to find solutions.

Seventy-nine years ago, the permanent members of the Security Council conferred on themselves the great responsibility of ensuring international peace and security and cooperating in good faith to save future generations from the transgressions of the past. With that great responsibility came the expectation that gross violations of the Charter of the United Nations would be dealt with resolutely and impartially. We placed our trust in them to act in the common interest, prevent conflict and preserve human dignity. The consequences of conflict are felt beyond the direct and intolerable suffering of victims in war zones and those displaced by fighting. In a very interconnected world, we are all subjected to inflationary pressures, elevated commodity and energy prices and other disruptive effects. Widened and prolonged conflict risks affecting smaller States like Seychelles, which are trying not to get caught in the crossfire. It is not our intention to lecture the world Powers or to attempt to prescribe solutions for complex issues. We simply wish to remind the

Council members of their duty and that they should assure us that geopolitics will not supersede human rights and international law.

Since its formation in 1946, the Security Council has remained largely unchanged. At the time most of Africa was under colonial rule. Seychelles joins the call for the United Nations and the Security Council to deliver the reform that so many have called for, with the goal not of hindering its work but of bringing inclusivity and perspective. It is time to correct one of the many injustices that Africa has been subjected to. Permanent membership of the world's primary peacekeeping institution is a necessity. The Council's consideration of critical issues, such as the matter of rising sea levels that Malta raised last year (see S/PV.9260) and the broader climate-security nexus, has proved that it is capable of reflecting new realities. The proposal by the United States to include a rotating seat for small island developing States is a welcome and progressive one.

Climate change remains the foremost challenge facing humankind, and failure to address its effects will devastate current and future generations. As a small island State, Seychelles understands what it means to be vulnerable. That vulnerability that cannot be ignored when it comes to the future we see for ourselves. We are on the front lines of the climate crisis, which poses irreversible threats to our people, our economy and our way of life. Rising sea levels, extreme weather events and the degradation of our oceans are stark reminders of the urgent need for global action on climate change. We have all made commitments, pledges and promises to achieve large-scale reductions of emissions, keep alive the goal of limiting global warming to 1.5°C, boosting adaptation to deal with extreme weather disasters and building resilience for addressing future impacts. But words are nothing without deeds, and we have to act urgently and in unity in order to make the necessary transition to a more sustainable future. It is a conscious and intentional choice to continue down that path and decide that business as usual in pursuit of short-term goals is acceptable.

World military expenditure has increased for the tenth consecutive year, reaching \$2.5 trillion in 2023, which makes even the highest estimates of the funds needed for loss and damage — \$100 billion — seem modest and insignificant. That is a worrisome reflection of the world's priorities. It is unfair for small island developing States (SIDS) to suffer the consequences of those choices. We simply do not have the means to cope with the disastrous effects of climate change. In that context, I want to thank those who have contributed to the loss and damage fund. The pledges made following the twenty-eighth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change should not be mere attempts to pacify those of us who have been calling for remediation. We hope to take it as a token of ongoing commitment and continued action, given the expected rise in the costs of dealing with climate change. As the Secretary-General said yesterday (see A/79/PV.7), those who shoulder the blame should foot the bill.

The international community cannot hope to advance sustainable development when some race ahead while others are left to struggle. No one should be left behind, lest we abandon future generations to a bleaker world. The obligations outlined in the Paris Agreement on Climate Change are the lifelines that would give us a chance if all States did their utmost to adhere to them. Our reliance on fossil fuels is unsustainable and detrimental. We must accelerate the energy transition towards renewables and mobilize investment in the related technology and infrastructure if we are to have any prospect of real energy security. Seychelles' focus remains on nature-based solutions to combat climate change while ensuring economic sustainability and environmental preservation. Our blue bonds demonstrate the potential for harnessing capital markets in order to finance the sustainable use of marine resources.

But ambitious and innovative strategies for securing long-term economic development are futile without finance that is accessible and sustainable. The average ratio of debt to gross domestic product in SIDS exceeds 70 per cent. It is crippling, and it impedes our development by diverting critical resources from where they are needed most — infrastructure, education and healthcare. Our vulnerabilities have expanded, but our borrowing costs remain high. Instead of being granted concessions, we are penalized for our vulnerability. It is time to move beyond discussion and implement real reforms in the international financial system to address the fact that some vulnerable countries, regardless of their income status, are precluded from opportunities to meet development needs. We must also recognize the humanitarian consequences of economic policies. Our work in the multilateral system is undermined by unilateral coercive measures that are intended to leave economies crippled and Governments unable to enhance their own people's dignity.

The multilateral system remains our best hope for addressing the challenges we face. As a small State, Seychelles believes in the United Nations, for we fear a reality with no alternative. In a world that is more interconnected than ever, multilateralism is the network that links our shared values to achieve the vision that we have for our world, one that is defined by our common interests and not our differences. We are here to solve problems, not to exacerbate them, to listen and not to dismiss. We put our faith in this institution because we must prove to the world that we can work for it, but it is up to us to make it work. In 2023, we adopted the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction, and this year Seychelles became the twelfth State in the world and the first in Africa to ratify it. We urge other countries to ratify it as soon as possible so as not to delay its entry into force.

This year's fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States in Antigua and Barbuda shone a timely light on the challenges that we face in a global economic landscape that we are ill equipped to navigate. The Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for Small Island Developing States has provided a blueprint for action over the next decade, and we call on the international community to commit to its implementation. The multidimensional vulnerability index resolution adopted here last month (resolution 78/322) also represents a triumph of the multilateral system in considering new approaches to complex and evolving issues. Its data and findings deliver the empirical grounding for what we know to be true, which is that a single-layered approach to development is no longer accurate or adequate. A better understanding of precisely those multidimensional vulnerabilities will be crucial to the decisions that we take, and more importantly, those taken on our behalf.

The Pact for the Future that the Assembly has just adopted (resolution 79/1) should rightly usher in a new era of engagement based on mutual interest and mutual respect. We must use it to bridge divisions between nations on critical issues of human rights, gender equality and the rule of law. The new era must accelerate the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals and shape the international financial system more fairly so that it can adapt responses to global crises in a more coordinated way and restore peace, with a promise to preserve it in future.

For Seychelles, the Declaration on Future Generations should signal our commitment to safeguarding the rights of all the people who will be born by the end of this century, most of them in developing countries — people who should not be born into hardship. We must envision a world where survival is not a struggle, a world that ensures everyone's right to prosperity. Basic rights should not be difficult to provide.

I firmly believe that those are the foundations on which our cooperation and progress should be built — the things that our people need most and that should

guide us towards building a world that is more secure and sustainable. Let us strive to be the architects of a world where no one is left behind.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Seychelles for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Wavel Ramkalawan, President of the Republic of Seychelles, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Czech Republic.

Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Pavel: It is a true honour for me to address the General Assembly today. Much to my regret, since the last time we met here, one year ago (see A/78/PV.5), the world has not become any safer — quite the contrary. To start with, I would like to recall that the United Nations was created to save humankind from the scourge of war and destruction and to promote peace, justice and a better quality of life for all humankind. Together, we have managed to build a global system of rules and cooperation, with the ambition of advancing security and human rights instead of conflicts and suffering, and of fostering economic development instead of ignoring mass destruction. Aligned around the Charter of the United Nations, we have subscribed to not repeating the mistakes and disasters of the past. Unfortunately, we still do.

The world and its citizens need and deserve an effective United Nations that can respond quickly when needed and deliver better on our shared global commitments. Without a functioning multilateral system, alternative and exclusive structures would lead to more fragmentation and less predictability. It is our duty as national and global leaders to find common solutions to the most pressing problems before they get out of hand. Finding a compromise is never easy. It requires time and patience. Only if we realize that we can achieve much more together than when we are antagonistic can we make our nations — and the United Nations — truly united behind common goals.

Comprehensive reform of the Security Council is long overdue. A Council that is more effective, inclusive and accountable, and better able to reflect today's realities by strengthening the voices of underrepresented regions, is crucially needed. In the face of the unjust and unprovoked Russian war against Ukraine, we must realize that Security Council membership is not *carte blanche* to act as we please. No one has the right to abuse power and bully other members of the international community without sanctions. Together we must put more pressure on Russia to end its unjust and brutal war. The peace summit in Switzerland clearly affirmed that peace in Ukraine must be based on international law and the principles of sovereignty and territorial integrity. The cynical nature of Russia's policy, and its lack of interest in genuine peace talks, has global consequences. They include impaired nuclear safety, diminished food and energy security and damage to the rules-based international order.

Czechia calls on those who have not yet supported our common effort to evaluate the possibility of signing the joint declaration agreed at the peace summit in Switzerland. So far, many who aspire to become respected regional or global actors have remained silent. But respect cannot be forced. It can only be earned. Let us not

forget that when we hesitate, we strengthen the aggressor. If leaders remain silent in the face of injustice and aggression, others will soon be waiting in line to see how far they can go in bending the international rules as they please. Some may think that Russia's actions against Ukraine are just another regional conflict and that both sides need to meet each other halfway. But there is no such thing as just a regional conflict. Conflicts in one part of the world cause food insecurity and create waves of refugees in others. With globalization, our security and prosperity start way beyond our own borders.

Being fully aware of that, Czechia is committed not only to the security of Europe but of the Middle East, Africa and elsewhere as well. I applaud the fact that many nations, including African ones, spare no effort to achieve and safeguard peace and security in their own regions and far beyond. Czechia will continue to engage with African countries and listen closely to their views and needs. I believe that despite political differences, together we can create mutually beneficial partnerships, based on the principles of equality and mutual respect and without any historical burden or future material demands. Africa is a continent with huge economic potential that is waiting to be unlocked. We want to see it flourish, enhance its capabilities and create opportunities and jobs for young people.

The last topic I want to touch on is cybersecurity and technology. With the growing digital transformation and our increasing reliance on advanced technology, the gravity and scale of cyberthreats are increasing and respect no borders. Cyberespionage and cyberattacks on our hospitals, media, infrastructure, national institutions and businesses aim to destabilize our democratic system and undermine its principles. Just as we do offline, we cannot allow cyberspace to become a lawless criminal world. The agreed framework of responsible behaviour of States in cyberspace should guide us in our efforts to strive for a safer online world. The security of cyberspace will depend on the capacities and efforts of all responsible States to enhance their own cyber capabilities. Czechia is taking its commitment to the protection of global cyberspace security very seriously. We will continue to provide assistance to our partners in Africa, Asia and South America so that together we can improve our resilience and protect our citizens even better.

Foreign interference and disinformation continue to present a challenge with a serious impact on democracy, security and the rules-based international order. With the rapid development of new technologies, the protection and promotion of human rights continue to be vital for our societies. Emerging technologies will have an indisputable influence on the nature of our future conflicts, but also on peace. It is our duty to ensure that innovations — including artificial intelligence, autonomous systems, biotechnology and quantum computing — fully conform to our ethical and human rights standards. Last year Czechia, together with Mexico, Maldives, the Kingdom of the Netherlands and South Africa, submitted a draft resolution on human rights in the context of digital technologies (resolution 78/213). Furthermore, last month, during the Globsec Security Forum, I sat down with top managers of global technology companies at the Prague GeoTech Summit. I was glad to hear that they are fully aware of their responsibility and committed to contributing to the resilience of democracy.

The challenges we are facing are global, and we can succeed only if we fully commit to collective action and greater cooperation. The quality of our governance will be judged by our actions and by whether we leave this world in a better condition for future generations. I would like to thank everyone who is working tirelessly to make our planet a safer and more secure place for all. That is what really matters.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Czech Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Petr Pavel, President of the Czech Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of Ukraine.

Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Zelenskyy: Today I want to tell you about a day that is already past, and a day that must never come. On the night of 4 March 2022, I received one of the most terrifying reports that I had had since the full-scale Russian invasion against Ukraine began. According to the report, Russian tanks were firing directly on the buildings of our Ukrainian nuclear power plant, the Zaporizhzhya nuclear power plant — the largest in Europe, with six nuclear reactors. The Russian army stormed that facility just as brutally as they have any other during this war, without thinking about the consequences, which were possibly disastrous. That was one of the most horrifying moments of the war. No one could know how the Russian strikes on the nuclear facility would end, and everyone in Ukraine was reminded of what Chernobyl means. Now, unfortunately, the Zaporizhzhya plant remains occupied by Russian forces, and it is at risk of a nuclear incident. It is the major source of potential radiation danger in Europe and possibly the world. That is why the first point of the peace formula I presented is about nuclear safety. In Ukraine, we know exactly what we are dealing with, and I want to thank the members of the General Assembly for adopting a resolution in July on the safety of nuclear facilities in Ukraine (resolution 78/316). Most people around the world understand what is at stake. The General Assembly demanded that Russia return control of the Zaporizhzhya power plant to Ukraine. Only then will real nuclear security return to Europe and the world.

I now turn to the day that must never come. Since Russia cannot defeat our people's resistance on the battlefield, Putin is looking for other ways to break the Ukrainian spirit. One of his methods is by targeting our energy infrastructure with deliberate attacks on our power plants and the entire energy grid. As of today, Russia has destroyed all of our thermal power plants and a large part of our hydroelectric capacity. That is how Putin is preparing for winter — hoping to torment millions of Ukrainians, ordinary families, women and children, in ordinary towns and villages. Putin wants to leave them in the dark and cold this winter, forcing Ukraine to suffer and surrender. I would like everyone here to imagine their country losing 80 per cent of its energy system. What kind of life would that be?

I recently received yet another alarming report from our intelligence. Putin now seems to be planning attacks on our nuclear power plants and their infrastructure and aiming to disconnect the plants from the power grid. With the help of satellites belonging to other countries, Russia is obtaining images and detailed information about the infrastructure of our nuclear power plants. But what does that really threaten? Any missile or drone strike, any critical incident in the energy system could lead to a nuclear disaster. A day like that must never come and Moscow needs to understand that. That depends, in part, on the Assembly's determination to put pressure on the aggressor. These are nuclear power plants. They must be safe.

Two years ago, in the fall of 2022, I proposed a comprehensive strategy to end the war and ensure security. I presented the peace formula at a highly inclusive political platform for world leaders — the Group of 20 Summit in Indonesia — representing

billions of citizens from all parts of the globe. It is important for us that all those people understand that Ukraine wants to end this war more than anyone in the world. War always poses a threat to many. We all see in the media and read in reports what is happening in Ukraine because of Russia's war. It is something that many can imagine happening to themselves. And yes, the smoke from fires in war-torn cities can reach other countries. If, God forbid, Russia caused a nuclear disaster at one of our nuclear power plants, the radiation would not respect State borders. Unfortunately, various nations could feel the devastating effects.

But while many are concerned, the deepest understanding of war is always found in the home it destroys. It is the Ukrainian people who are feeling the full pain of this war. It is Ukrainian children who are learning to distinguish the sounds of different types of artillery and drones because of Russia's war. It is our people who are forcibly separated by occupation because Putin decided he could do whatever he wants. It is our heroic soldiers who are giving their lives to defend our country from invaders trying to steal our land. That is why we say — and rightly — that there can be no just peace without Ukraine.

I thank every leader and country that supports us in that, that understands us and sees how Russia, a country more than 20 times larger than Ukraine in terms of territory, still wants even more land — which is insane — and is seizing it, day by day, while wanting to destroy its neighbour. Russia has found very special buddies for that purpose — North Korea and Iran, a telling choice of friends. Now every neighbour of Russia in Europe and Central Asia feels that the war could come to them as well. We can imagine what kind of losses that would mean for the world.

I thank the nearly 100 nations and international organizations that have supported the peace formula. It is truly a global community — in Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America, North America and the Pacific region — all united by the peace formula. I am glad that the first peace summit was so reminiscent of the General Assembly. Everyone was equal. No nation that participated in the peace summit, large or small, had veto rights or the authority to block anything. The participants included countries that have long been independent and some that gained independence only recently. There were countries that have been through wars themselves, and countries accustomed to peace. All were equal. That is what Russia hates the most and cannot control. That is why Russia says the peace formula does not suit it.

Here at the United Nations, I have already met with leaders from India, Guatemala, Japan, Italy, Türkiye, Finland, Canada, Paraguay, Slovenia, Germany and others, and my meetings will continue. Those countries represent different parts of the world and various political ways of life, but they share the same understanding, which is that peace is needed, and it must be a real, just peace. Unfortunately, at the United Nations it is impossible to truly and fairly resolve matters of war and peace because in the Security Council too much depends on the power of the veto. When the aggressor exercises the veto, the United Nations is powerless to stop the war. But the peace formula can stop it. That is because, once again, there is no veto power in it. That is why it is the best opportunity for peace. Everyone is equal, and it is effective and comprehensive. When some propose alternatives, such as half-hearted settlement plans — so-called sets of principles — they not only ignore both reality and the interests and suffering of Ukrainians, who are the most affected by the war, they also give Putin the political space to continue the war and pressure the world to bring more nations under control. Any parallel or alternative attempts to seek peace are in fact efforts to achieve a lull instead of an end to the war. As a global initiative, the peace formula has already existed for two years. Perhaps there is someone who wants a Nobel Prize for their political biography — through a frozen truce instead of a real peace — but the only prizes that Putin will give them in return are more suffering and disaster.

We must restore nuclear safety. Energy must stop being used as a weapon. We must ensure food security. We need to bring home all of our captured soldiers and civilians who have been forcibly deported to Russia. We must uphold the Charter of the United Nations and guarantee our right — Ukraine's right — to territorial integrity and sovereignty, just as we do for any other nation. We need to withdraw the Russian occupiers, which will bring an end to the hostilities in Ukraine. We must hold those responsible for war crimes accountable. We need to prevent ecocide and stop the destruction of nature caused by the war. We must not allow a second or third phase of Russia's invasion. And we need to make it clear that the war is over.

That is the peace formula. What part of that could be unacceptable to anyone who upholds the Charter? If anyone is seeking alternatives to any of those points or trying to ignore any of them, it likely means that they themselves want to take part in what Putin is doing — ignoring those points reveals the desire that they are hiding. And when the Chinese-Brazilian duo tries to expand into a choir of voices — with someone in Europe or Africa proposing some kind of alternative to a full and just peace — the question that arises is what their true interest is. It is important for all to understand that they cannot boost their own power at Ukraine's expense.

The world has already been through colonial wars and conspiracies of great Powers at the expense of those that are smaller. Every country, including China, Brazil and nations in Europe, Africa and the Middle East, understands why that must remain in the past. And Ukrainians will never accept why anyone in the world would believe that such a brutal colonial past, which suits no one today, could now be imposed on Ukraine instead of a normal, peaceful life. I want peace for my people — real and just peace. I am asking for the support of every nation in the world. Ukraine does not divide the world. I ask the same of everyone here. I ask them not to divide the world. If we are nations united, that will bring us peace. Glory to Ukraine.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Ukraine for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Volodymyr Zelenskyy, President of Ukraine, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, President of the Republic of Ghana

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Ghana.

Mr. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, President of the Republic of Ghana, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, President of the Republic of Ghana, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Akufo-Addo: I cannot help but reflect on the significance of this moment, as it is my final opportunity to address the General Assembly as I enter the closing months of my presidency. Over the past eight years, I have had the privilege of speaking about several variations on the essential themes that quite properly dominate the deliberations of this global Assembly — the condition of humankind and the state of the planet. Serving the people of Ghana, and by extension those of West Africa, Africa and the world, has truly been the greatest blessing of my life. Indeed, being here this morning fills me with both pride and humility — pride in the limited progress that we have made together as nations, and humility in recognizing the challenges that still remain. My time as President has been deeply fulfilling, and

I am profoundly grateful for the trust placed in me by my fellow Ghanaians. It has been an honour to serve them and to contribute to advancing peace, security and development on the global stage.

I am here with a heart full of hope, yet mindful of the great challenges that still confront us. As President of the Republic of Ghana and a citizen of the world, I am acutely aware of the shared responsibility we carry. Our work here is nothing less than shaping the future of humankind — a future that will affect generations long after we are gone. The theme of this session's general debate, "Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations", reminds us that the decisions we take here will define whether we rise to meet the hopes of billions or continue to let inequities and injustices persist. We owe it to those who look to this Organization for leadership to act and not just to talk.

The world we live in today is a stark, unfortunate contrast of privilege and hardship. For too long, the voices of those marginalized — those left behind — have been drowned out. They constitute the bulk of humankind. They are the voices of the poor, the displaced and the vulnerable. We cannot in good conscience leave them behind. They should be at the centre of our discussions and decisions.

Africa in particular knows the cost of being left out. Yes, we are a continent rich in potential and resilient in the face of adversity, but we have also been disadvantaged by a global system that has generally treated us as an afterthought. We have been viewed merely as passive recipients of aid rather than equal partners in global progress. The well-meaning promises of assistance have failed to materialize to bring about the long-term change we so passionately need. Such aid as is offered often comes with strings attached, limiting our ability to shape our own futures. Africa is not a continent of despair — it is full of great possibilities. It is required, however, to chart a new course of development. Our young population is filled with energy, creativity and ambition. The people of Africa are not asking for handouts. They are demanding opportunities in a new global architecture so that they can have access to education, healthcare and jobs to be able to build better lives for themselves, their families and their descendants.

In Ghana, we have taken bold and decisive steps to ensure that no one is left behind in our national development, and we have shown that it is possible. My country's flagship Free Senior High School policy has benefited 5.7 million young people, many of whom would have been denied the opportunity to learn, dream and succeed. That initiative has transformed the lives of millions, positioning the next generation of Ghanaians to take their place as leaders in the global economy. But that is just the beginning. We need a global commitment to ensuring that all children, no matter where they are born, have access to quality education. A world in which children are left unprepared for the challenges ahead is not a just world.

Beyond education, we have also prioritized healthcare for our people. Through Ghana's Agenda 111, my Government has embarked on the largest-ever healthcare infrastructure project in Ghana's history. That initiative is constructing 111 hospitals across the country, ensuring that even the most remote regions have access to modern healthcare facilities. That is part of our broader goal of ensuring that no one in Ghana is left without the basic right to health.

We have also taken significant steps to boost food security and economic growth through the Planting for Food and Jobs programme. That initiative has improved food production, created jobs and enhanced incomes for millions of Ghanaians. It is a clear demonstration that, with the right policies and investments, we can transform our agricultural sector and ensure that no one goes hungry. In the same vein, our One-District, One-Factory policy is transforming the industrial landscape of the

nation, generating the structural transformation of our economy, which is our major strategic objective.

In addition, Ghana has embraced, in full, the teachings of the fourth industrial revolution and is actively pursuing an agenda of digitalization. Under my Administration, we have revolutionized public service delivery by integrating technology into governance. From the introduction of the Ghana Card, which has streamlined identification and access to services, to the digitalization of the country's land registry, such reforms have enhanced transparency, efficiency and accountability. Digitalization has improved the lives of ordinary Ghanaians and has also laid the groundwork for sustainable economic growth in the digital age. And let us not forget the strides that we have made in enhancing the rule of law and governance. Through reforms in the judicial system, strengthening our democratic institutions and promoting transparency, Ghana continues to be a beacon of good governance in Africa. We have enacted laws and have implemented policies that uphold the principles of accountability and ensure that every Ghanaian, regardless of their background, is protected by the rule of law.

It is impossible to address the challenges of today without speaking of the contradictions that exist within this global institution. We gather here to discuss peace, but wars continue to ravage nations. We speak of justice, yet injustice endures. Take the Russian invasion of Ukraine, for instance. Millions of lives have been uprooted, thousands have lost their lives, and yet the Security Council has struggled to respond decisively, just as it is struggling to intervene decisively in the tragic, ongoing wars in Gaza and Lebanon. The structure of the Council reflects a world that no longer exists, and its failure to act in times of crisis raises a difficult question: What is the purpose of the Security Council if it cannot intervene when the world needs it most?

Reforming the Security Council is a matter of fairness and necessity. The current structure, created in 1945, no longer reflects the realities of today's geopolitical and economic landscape. Africa, Latin America and South Asia remain underrepresented, despite their significant influence on global affairs. That lack of representation undermines the legitimacy of the Council's decisions, and the use of the right of the veto by a few permanent members often paralyzes its ability to act effectively during crises. Reform is essential to ensure that the Council is more inclusive, democratic and responsive to the complex challenges we face today. The world has changed, and the Security Council must change with it to maintain its relevance in promoting global peace and security.

For years, I have championed the need to reform the Security Council as per the Ezulwini Consensus — the Common African Position on the reform of the United Nations — which calls for Africa to have permanent seats on the Council. It is incomprehensible that a continent of 1.4 billion people has no permanent voice in shaping decisions that affect global peace and security. The time for half-measures is over. We need a Security Council that is fit for purpose in today's world. It is heartening, however, that the demand for reform has finally found acceptance by leaders of two of the five permanent members: President Joe Biden of the United States of America and President Emmanuel Macron of France. Hopefully, the others will soon follow suit.

We must also recognize that the fight for peace goes beyond Government actions. It is a fight for humanity itself. In Africa, we have often borne the brunt of conflicts, sending our troops to peacekeeping missions with limited support from the global community. While I am pleased to see the United Nations now taking steps to finance peacekeeping in Africa, an outcome of Ghana's presidency of the Security Council, we must go farther. Peacekeeping alone is not enough. We must address the potential causes of conflict — poverty, inequality and the lack of opportunity. True

peace comes from investing in education, healthcare and economic development. However, peace cannot be imposed from the outside. It must be built from within. African nations must take ownership of their security, and the African Union needs to strengthen itself to be able to respond swiftly to threats.

As I speak today, ongoing developments in West Africa are deeply troubling. Military coups in Mali, Guinea, Burkina Faso and the Niger threaten the democratic progress that we have worked so hard to achieve within the Economic Community of West African States. The coups are stark reminders that democracy is indeed fragile and must be continually nurtured. In Ghana, however, we remain resolute in our commitment to democracy. As my presidency draws to a close, I want to assure the Assembly that the upcoming 2024 elections in Ghana will be free, fair and transparent. Ghanaians have demonstrated time and time again, in the past three decades, their strong attachment to democracy, which they will not permit to be undermined. The Electoral Commission, supported by Ghana's security services, is well equipped to ensure that the will of the Ghanaian people is respected. Ghana has long been a beacon of democracy in Africa, and we intend to keep it that way. The 2024 elections will be proof of our enduring adherence to the rule of law, transparency and the principles of democratic accountability that have guided our nation in recent decades.

We find ourselves at a pivotal moment in history. The decisions that we make today will shape the future of our world. We can choose to act with courage, compassion and a commitment to leave no one behind, or we can choose inaction and allow the suffering of millions and the degradation of the planet to continue.

Let me end by reminding us all that the future is not something that simply happens; it is something that we create. We have the power in this Hall to change the course of history. Let us not shy away from that responsibility. Let us act now, and let us act together. I wish everyone God's blessings in all their current and future deliberations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Ghana for the statement he has just made.

Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo, President of the Republic of Ghana, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Rumen Radev, President of the Republic of Bulgaria

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Bulgaria.

Mr. Rumen Radev, President of the Republic of Bulgaria, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Rumen Radev, President of the Republic of Bulgaria, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Radev: Allow me at the outset to congratulate His Excellency Mr. Philémon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I believe that, under his leadership and through his vision, the international community will move forward on the agenda of strengthening the values of the Charter of the United Nations — an effort that humankind needs more than ever.

Our world faces a range of complex problems — from unprecedented challenges to global peace and security to the escalating climate crisis and persistent inequalities. We are confronted with a complex array of issues that require our immediate attention

and concerted effort. We need to light a spark that ignites change. With that in mind, my country is looking forward to the seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly with renewed determination to promote multilateral and workable solutions achieved through negotiations and based on the Charter. We must follow that path for the sake of the survival of humankind and future generations.

Taking that into consideration, we praise the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) as a move towards a vital transformation. It becomes increasingly clear that our success hinges on a firm commitment to upholding multilateralism and respect for international law, which are the cornerstones of our global order. That order, which has been forged at the United Nations by the representatives here and their predecessors, is now under severe threat. Bulgaria has always been committed to the values of multilateralism and will remain so, using our accumulated experience from the successful Bulgarian presidency of the Economic and Social Council and our current mandate as a constructive member of the Human Rights Council.

In 2015, all United Nations Member States unanimously adopted 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), providing a shared blueprint for peace and prosperity for the entire planet. Today the Goals remain more topical than ever and require a full mobilization of international efforts. However, we must admit that the sheer deterioration of the international peace and security environment in recent years is threatening the fulfilment of our 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, undermining the rules-based international order. Restoring and preserving peace must be seen as the ultimate goal of the international community and is a basic prerequisite for the fulfilment of the SDGs.

It has been two and a half years since the Russian Federation unleashed a full-scale invasion of Ukraine. From the very beginning, Bulgaria has strongly condemned the war, which has led to hundreds of thousands of victims, enormous suffering and destruction. Every single day of the war increases the risk of escalation in intensity and geographical scope, posing a substantial threat to global peace and security. The side effects of the war are already gravely affecting the economies and social systems of many countries worldwide. That is why the international community should seek paths that lead to de-escalation and dialogue. We should support every diplomatic effort that pursues comprehensive, just and lasting peace in Ukraine, in conformity with the Charter of the United Nations and international law.

Since last year's general debate, we have witnessed a significant increase in instability across the Middle East. The conflict between Israel and Hamas, after the latter's brutal attack on Israel, triggered a major deterioration of the security situation in the region, with global projections. We must not forget the consequences that followed: tens of thousands dead or injured civilians in Gaza, the total destruction of vital infrastructure and the mass displacement of people. We call for an immediate ceasefire and free access for humanitarian convoys, as well as the release of all hostages held by Hamas. We are also deeply concerned about recent developments in Lebanon, bringing a qualitative new and dangerous dimension to the conflict and increasing the risk of its regional enlargement. We call on the parties to refrain from the use of force, turn to wisdom and seek de-escalation. The spiral of violence and the human suffering must come to an end. The only way to achieve sustainable and lasting peace in the region, with its very fragile security landscape, is the two-State solution.

Amid the ongoing destabilization across different regions, the collective goal for a world without nuclear threats remains more critical than ever. In line with the New Agenda for Peace, Bulgaria will maintain its commitment to uphold, protect and strengthen the multilateral framework for disarmament, non-proliferation and arms control. We remain dedicated to the universalization and full implementation of the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons, which we recognize

as the cornerstone of the global nuclear non-proliferation regime. It serves as the essential foundation for pursuing nuclear disarmament and plays a crucial role in the development of nuclear energy for peaceful purposes.

As we address those challenges, prioritizing regional stability becomes vital. My country is actively engaged in political dialogue with South-East European countries, driven by the conviction that the region's security, stability and prosperity are crucial for broader regional and international resilience. Bulgaria is a strong supporter of the European path of the Western Balkan countries. Our main priorities vis-à-vis the region are fostering good neighbourliness, improving connectivity, protecting human rights and combating ethnic discrimination. However, a serious challenge along that path is posed by new outbursts of incitements of hatred. Fighting and curbing the aggressive nationalistic rhetoric all over the region and concentrating on a positive agenda of strengthening multi-ethnic societies and the rights of the constituent communities will prevent an evocation of the region's troubled past.

Progress in achieving the Sustainable Development Goals is the greatest investment for the benefit of current and future generations. Bulgaria continues to contribute actively to those common efforts through the steady implementation of its national development programme towards 2030 and of sustainable projects for development cooperation with partner countries. We are supporting projects in the fields of education, healthcare and public infrastructure and services, as well as renewable energy solutions.

In a growing number of places around the world, we face the emergence of worrisome dynamics in terms of governance, democracy and human rights. As a current member of the Human Rights Council, we reaffirm our commitment to that noble cause. Bulgaria has never looked the other way, and that is demonstrated through our domestic policies; our membership of the Human Rights Council; our work as a co-Chair of the Group of Friends for Children and Sustainable Development Goals, as Vice-President of the UNICEF Bureau, as a member of the Executive Board of UN-Women; and our support for initiatives that empower the General Assembly and are aimed at ensuring accountability. Our advocacy for the meaningful participation of civil society, youth and women in decision-making processes — both across the United Nations system and domestically — have already yielded results, and our youth delegate programme inspires more young people to choose the path of active citizenship. Bulgaria advocates for a human rights-based approach to sustainable development and looks forward to the inclusion of all stakeholders at the upcoming second World Summit for Social Development.

We have focused on peace among nations, but it is equally important to reconcile with nature. Climate change is a threat multiplier for the implementation of all Sustainable Development Goals. We call for enhanced action based on the first global stocktaking of the Paris Agreement and for more ambitious climate objectives, including the new finance goal agreed at the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change. Earlier this year, Bulgaria hosted the sixty-first session of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, which gave impetus to the Panel's seventh assessment cycle, including the production of the *Special Report on Climate Change and Cities*. Through various Panel events, we were able to invigorate a science-based discussion, paying due attention to the climate risks in the Black Sea region, as well as to the urban environment, the role of cities and the need to adapt to a changing climate.

Another challenge that also brings a lot of opportunities is the need for effective digital governance, based on a multi-stakeholder and inclusive approach and aimed at a human-centric digital transformation and a safe and open digital future.

In the light of growing challenges to the principles of international law and the rules-based order established by the Charter, Bulgaria remains committed to strengthening the effectiveness and accountability of the Security Council. We support efforts to enhance transparency and accountability within that body, having co-sponsored the key General Assembly resolution on veto use (resolution 76/262). Bulgaria emphasizes the need for greater effectiveness and prioritizes securing an additional non-permanent seat for the Group of Eastern European States in a reformed Council.

Let us reaffirm our commitment to addressing these global challenges with firmness and determination. The action we take today will define the future, and with courage and unity, we will rise to meet the opportunities that lie ahead.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Bulgaria for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Rumen Radev, President of the Republic of Bulgaria, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Chandrikapersad Santokhi, President of the Republic of Suriname

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Suriname.

Mr. Chandrikapersad Santokhi, President of the Republic of Suriname, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Chandrikapersad Santokhi, President of Suriname, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Santokhi: This General Assembly session is of historic significance, as we embark on a process of recalibrating international relations and establishing a more effective multilateral framework. I therefore extend my heartfelt congratulations to the President on his election to preside over this esteemed body. Allow me also to congratulate the outgoing President from Trinidad and Tobago on a job well done under difficult circumstances.

This Organization was founded after two devastating world wars. Its original purpose remains relevant today — to save current and future generations from the disastrous consequences of wars and armed conflicts and to foster peace and political stability for sustained prosperity for all. We, however, observe instead that the world is marked by a complex political and security crisis, weakening our global multilateral framework of collective solidarity, international law and respect for humanitarian law. The conflicts that divide us are not isolated incidents. They are symptoms of deeper systemic challenges, rising inequality, environmental degradation and the breakdown of global trust.

The time has come to dare to make bold decisions, to revisit our global governance architecture and to recommit to the original goals of the United Nations.

With statistics showing that countries are not on track to implement the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, while projections estimate that almost 600 million people will continue to live in extreme poverty in 2030, it is incumbent upon us to close the gap between aspiration and financing. I wish to emphasize the urgent need for accelerated reforms and coordination within the international financial architecture, especially the international financial institutions. The multidimensional vulnerability index (MVI) offers a comprehensive and inclusive framework that goes beyond traditional metrics to capture the true complexity of

the vulnerabilities of small island developing States and low-lying coastal States. We urgently call for the MVI to be embedded in the operations of the international, financial institutions, especially the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank.

Apart from the multidimensional vulnerability index, we see other financial obstacles in place that have a major negative impact on our ability to generate development, especially the de-risking measures of international banks, which are based on general assessments and do not consider the countries' reality and the severe impact on a given country's development objectives. That must be addressed head-on if we want to be inclusive, rather than exclusive.

My country, Suriname, can attest to the vitally urgent need to reform the global financial and political system and to build greater trust in the multilateral system. Because of our ranking, we are not eligible for several global financial instruments, to the detriment of my people. Since taking office in July 2020, my Government has successfully started a policy of financial-economic reforms, including restructuring the debt portfolio, supported by an IMF programme and international financial institutions.

The impact of the various crises and of national efforts to reform the economy has not been easy for the population, but we are on the road to recovery now; macroeconomic stability has been achieved. We established a social safety net and increased several social benefits, all meant to make sure that we did not forget or exclude that part of our population from restoring a healthier economy.

Statistics from 2024 reveal that progress in the area of climate action is inadequate, with global greenhouse gas emissions still rising, despite the need for reductions. Climate action can no longer be postponed or ignored. Soon, we will meet in Azerbaijan for the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change. Will we be repeating ourselves with empty promises and pledges? Or will we take decisive action to save this planet from extinction?

Suriname is committed to the Paris Agreement. Suriname has also submitted ambitious, nationally determined contributions and has recently started the process of carbon credit trading. Suriname aims to remain a carbon-negative country, with a high level of biodiversity and more than 90 per cent forest coverage. With that conscious choice to limit deforestation, we sacrifice economic development for our people. For that, we are not compensated, while everyone benefits from our decision. Carbon-negative and carbon-neutral countries must be supported for maintaining those statuses.

We are in favour of a just transition to a carbon-free economy over the coming decades, but we also expect to be allowed to develop our natural resources in an environmentally friendly and balanced manner, in compliance with international standards and practices. In fact, we have already embarked on such a development path by introducing more renewables into our energy grid, utilizing technological innovations to reduce our carbon footprint even further.

Over the past 100 years, Suriname has had industrial development of the bauxite industry, onshore oil production and gold production, in addition to agricultural production and other industries. Despite those activities, Suriname is among the three carbon-negative countries in the world. At the same time, Suriname is among the seven most vulnerable countries with respect to the effects of rising sea levels. Not only have the international pledges for climate financing not materialized as pledged, but access to the available resources is an enormous challenge. The application and appraisal procedures must be simplified so as to achieve the required impact at a local level. Regrettably, we also observe that a large part of those funds has been

diverted into time-consuming and expensive studies, consultancies and advisory services. In the meantime, the situation on the ground in the affected regions and countries is deteriorating. Often, the requested assistance comes too late.

To transform the well-being of our communities, we must embrace diversity and work towards social justice and inclusion. That is what responsible leaders do — ensure that no one is left out or excluded. We must practice what we preach. While the humanitarian and security situation in the Republic of Haiti remains of concern, we are pleased to note that, partly through the leadership of the Caribbean Community, a road map towards free and fair elections has been initiated and a transition Government with a clear mandate has been installed. We cannot leave Haiti and its people alone and behind. Haiti fatigue is not an option. We urge the international community to financially and technically support Haiti on its path forward. Suriname will contribute security personnel to the Multinational Security Support Mission and remains committed to assisting it in whatever way we can. We call for a more effective, coordinated and coherent approach and for the transparent sharing of information regarding the different initiatives so as to more effectively serve the Haitian people and the objectives of facilitating peace, security and prosperity in Haiti.

Leaving no one behind should also include lifting the long-standing economic embargo against Cuba and its people. The adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) represents an opportunity to chart a new path for humankind so as to address current challenges while laying the groundwork for sustainable solutions. We need to foster collaboration and strengthen partnerships if we are to address long-term global issues such as climate change, social inequality and access to affordable healthcare and quality education for all. Small nations need support for digital transformation and to be provided with the tools and capacity-building initiatives needed for them to fully integrate into the global digital economy. We must utilize technology in a positive and constructive manner in order to facilitate financial inclusion for all and access to general education and skills training, telemedicine and treatment and instant Government services.

This year, 2024, marks the fifth time that I am addressing the General Assembly. In 2020, I delivered my maiden address (see A/75/PV.7) remotely through the use of modern technology. At that time, I remarked that multilateralism had come under attack on several occasions. Four years later, we still have a long way to go. We must work collectively and with a sense of urgency and a positive attitude towards renewing our commitment to a multilateral framework that is more inclusive, equitable and accountable, with the ultimate goal of creating a better, safer and more productive planet for our people, now and in future.

In conclusion, the theme of leaving no one behind is a call to action, but is also a challenge. For smaller countries like Suriname, the global system often perpetuates exclusion, which at times assumes new guises. As we reaffirm our renewed commitment to building a more just, inclusive and equitable international system in which accountability is important, together we must ensure that no nation, community, individual, woman or child is excluded or left behind when it comes to the promise of peace, prosperity and dignity. Let us live up to the spirit of “one for all and all for one”. May God bless us all.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Suriname for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Chandrikapersad Santokhi, President of the Republic of Suriname, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Cyprus.

Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Christodoulides: At the outset, I wish to congratulate His Excellency Ambassador Philémon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. He can count on the steadfast of Cyprus support for his mission.

I humbly stood at this podium for the first time last year (see A/78/PV.6). My main premise then was that the Charter of the United Nations was not a reality, but a promise — a sacred pledge that we inherited from our predecessors, from those who had the remarkable courage and clarity of vision to put pen to paper, to turn vision into action and to solemnly declare: “never again”. Those great visionaries, who had the audacity to build peace upon the smouldering ashes of war, assumed the tremendous responsibility to look beyond the horrors of the past, to learn from history — however painful it may be — and to lay the foundations of a world anchored in peace and stability and respect for international law and the sovereignty and territorial integrity of States — a world that leaves no one behind and ensures prosperity and human dignity for all. Like a burning torch, lit from those ashes, that promise was passed on to us. Our predecessors’ voices are echoed in the halls of this building, which stands as a beacon and a symbol of the only path towards the fulfilment of the United Nations Charter, which each and every State and each and every one of us undertook to uphold: multilateralism, respect for international law, diplomacy, the peaceful settlement of disputes, cooperation instead of the use of force and aggression, the laying down of arms and a world order that does not appease the aggressor or the violator of international legality.

Only a few weeks after last year’s General Assembly, on 7 October 2023, the world was shocked by the unimaginable and horrendous brutality of the terrorist attack perpetrated against innocent civilians. No one was spared the blindness and cruelty of the terror that Saturday morning: women raped, children killed and abducted, the elderly witnessing the burning flames of their loved ones, whose future was extinguished before their eyes and whose screams penetrated their hearts, forever changing the landscape of their lives, and penetrated the conscience of humankind. There is never justification for terror. There is never justification for such blatant disregard for human life and dignity, no matter where that life comes from, no matter whom it concerns. It concerns us all. When rape is used as a weapon of war against women and girls, when children are abducted, our voice needs to be loud, clear, united and unequivocal: those are our daughters; those are our children. And we failed them. Let me be clear: ours is a mission to help the innocent. Innocence knows no country, age, race or religion. Human pain and human dignity are equal for all, and the latter must be upheld always, in each and every context.

In the immediate aftermath of the attack of 7 October 2023 and as the humanitarian situation in Gaza deteriorated, my country, the Republic of Cyprus, acted. We acted on our moral responsibility to help the innocent civilians — men, women and children — of Gaza suffering abhorrent conditions that no human should ever endure. As a country that is an integral part of the region, Cyprus built on the long-standing bonds of friendship and trust with our neighbours.

Fulfilling our duty as an anchor of stability in a turbulent sea, as the lighthouse of the European Union (EU) in the Eastern Mediterranean, we delivered the Amalthea maritime corridor to the international community — a lifeline of hope and humanity. The Cyprus humanitarian corridor is a manifestation of the letter and spirit of the Charter of the United Nations: cooperation and multilateralism. It aptly demonstrates the power of diplomacy, which is one of our most powerful tools. Cyprus worked closely with regional and international partners, such as the United Arab Emirates and the United States, with the concrete support of the European Union and the United Nations, united by a shared vision. Those guiding principles are the beacon of our engagement in international relations — the power of diplomacy as a force for good. We have consistently manifested that commitment and will continue to do so. Cyprus has acted, time and time again, as a regional evacuation hub at times of crisis — a safe bridge and a safe haven for civilians.

The children of Palestine, who have been orphaned and forced to live in tents, with no access to the most basic items of existence, namely, food, shelter, education and safety, are also our children. No child should ever endure such a nightmare. They did not cause the war; they do not deserve it. They suffer in silence. Their cries haunt our conscience. We have failed them, too. The situation in Gaza is a desperate cry for us to act decisively. We must do all that is in our power, and we must act, as leaders, States and international and regional organizations. My country has emphatically stressed the need for respect for international humanitarian law, the protection of civilians, the rapid, safe and unhindered flow of humanitarian aid into Gaza and the immediate and unconditional release of all hostages. The war must end now. The suffering must stop now. We have also consistently underlined and acted on the imperative of avoiding further escalation and destabilization in our region and the vital importance of preventing regional escalation. We are deeply alarmed by the recent developments in our neighbouring Lebanon and stress the need for restraint. We must take a step back from the brink.

The wider region of the Eastern Mediterranean and the greater Middle East — our neighbourhood — is no doubt a turbulent region, faced with a multitude of complex challenges. And yet that neighbourhood is so much more than the prevailing narrative. I will never accept the linear narrative of a region in turmoil. It is a narrative that ignores the complexities but also the immense promise of the region and its people, the dynamics of opportunity and change that are unfolding. I have watched the journey closely, witnessing the fruit of cooperation in the region, experiencing first-hand what countries of the region can achieve when they come together behind a common vision for the future, committed to multilateralism, always with respect for international legality. And I am convinced that the Eastern Mediterranean and the wider Middle East can move decisively beyond the prevailing narrative of being a region in turmoil and become a hub of stability, peace and cooperation.

For the region to fulfil its promise, there must be a path for lasting peace. There is an urgent need to reinvigorate the Middle East peace process and reach a political settlement in line with the relevant Security Council resolutions. There is no other path to take. After the tragedy and suffering of the past year, let us exert every effort to ensure that there is a lifeline to peace. There are no shortcuts, no alternatives or substitutes to a lasting peace. There are no frozen conflicts. The vacuum created in the absence of a viable peace becomes a breeding ground for crisis and conflict. We can never be complacent. That is a painful lesson that recent history has taught us over and over again.

The Russian invasion of Ukraine — a sovereign nation — came as yet another stark reminder of what is at stake if we do not defend and uphold the principles enshrined in the United Nations Charter. Cyprus strongly condemns any breach of international peace and security effected through military action — by any

State — against the independence, sovereignty and territorial integrity of another. Since the first day of Russian invasion, my country has stood unwaveringly on the right side of history. Cyprus, my country, itself a victim of invasion and continuing occupation, has steadfastly supported the unity, territorial integrity and sovereignty of Ukraine.

The torch for peace in Cyprus is waiting to be lit. This year, on 20 July, we mourned 50 years since the Turkish invasion of Cyprus. Through use of force, Türkiye currently occupies a sovereign European State. It is violating the sovereignty and territorial integrity of an EU member State. It has been 50 years, half a century, of continuing Turkish occupation of approximately 37 per cent of the territory of the Republic of Cyprus; of the continuous violation of the United Nations Charter, international law, including international humanitarian and human rights law; 50 years of the displaced stoically waiting to return to their ancestral homes; 50 years of the mothers of the missing stoically awaiting the remains of their loved ones to be laid to rest in peace; half a century of blatant disregard for the Security Council resolutions that have also called for the return of the fenced town of Varosha to its lawful inhabitants and its transfer to the administration of the United Nations. And yet, they have also been 50 years of resilience and hope for peace by Cypriots; a burning desire and a deep belief by my people, by all Cypriots, that this cannot be the future of Cyprus. It cannot be the future of our children and the generations to come. They deserve to live and thrive in coexistence and co-creation in a reunified country, in conditions of viable peace.

I am often asked if I am optimistic about peace in Cyprus after 50 years. Let me recall the words of Jean Monnet, one of the inspired founders of the European Union, when he proclaimed that this is not a time for blind optimism or paralysing pessimism; now is the time to be determined. And so, the answer is that I am determined to work tirelessly and bravely for peace in Cyprus, to reunify my country and its people in a modern, viable European State, with no troops of occupation and no foreign guarantees. I am determined to provide for all Cypriots all the rights and fundamental freedoms that other Europeans enjoy. They deserve nothing less. I am determined not to fail them. To my Turkish Cypriot and Greek Cypriot compatriots, I say that I hear their call for peace. It has not faded over time. It has grown louder, more determined. We look to the United Nations and to the Secretary-General, who understands the imperative of reunification, to fulfil the promise of peace and to deliver on the pledge of the United Nations Charter.

I am determined to continue exerting all efforts to resume negotiations for a viable solution to the Cyprus issue within the only framework — the relevant Security Council resolutions, which call for a bizonal, bicomunal federation with political equality, as defined by the resolutions, and fully in line with EU law, values and principles.

Since the last time I stood before the Assembly in this Hall, we have made every effort to resume the peace process. There is no alternative to the path of peace. I am committed, and I am ready to sit at the negotiating table today — not tomorrow, today. I have clarity of vision for the future of my country, for the future of our children, in a reunified, prosperous, viable European State.

To Mr. Erdoğan, I say: History will judge us. And history is unforgiving in the light it casts on leaders who have an opportunity to deliver peace and, instead, choose the path of revisionism and disregard for international law. Those who want to lead must lead by example. The voice of morality cannot have selective historical amnesia, or selective sensitivity to violations of international law. The aggressor, the violator of international law, cannot be the advocate of legality, nor point a finger at others.

At this podium yesterday, we heard Mr. Erdoğan advocate disregarding the United Nations Charter and violating Security Council resolutions and international law, including the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (see A/79/PV.7). And my response, the response of the international community, is clear — illegality stemming from invasion, aggression and the use of force cannot be recognized. International law is not à la carte; its interpretation does not change depending on who the violator is. It applies equally to all contexts and to all countries. It applies to Türkiye, a country that 50 years ago used force in violation of the United Nations Charter, invaded a sovereign State, and is an occupation force in Cyprus. It is an affront to the Assembly to call an invasion a peace operation. Revisionism cannot change reality — not now, not ever.

To Mr. Erdoğan, I also say: Now is the time to deliver on his proclaimed commitment to international law and to peace. No country that believes in the moral superiority of its position refuses to sit at the negotiating table. I adamantly believe that we can carve a new path — one of peace, cooperation and collaboration. We cannot change geography. It is an opportunity, not a curse. Türkiye and Cyprus will always remain neighbours. Let us change the narrative. Let us transform our proximity into a promise. Let us build together a legacy of peace that can be transformative for the whole region.

In Our Common Agenda (A/75/982), the Secretary-General remarked that humankind faces a stark and urgent choice — “a breakdown or a breakthrough”. I welcome the Secretary-General’s New Agenda for Peace and support multilateral efforts towards peace and security. Collective action is urgently needed to address the changing nature of conflicts, including challenges posed by new technologies, the climate emergency, rising inequalities and backtracking on human rights. Halfway to the deadline, it is alarming that our world is off-track to achieve the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

Despite some glimmers of hope, action, transformative solutions and comprehensive reforms are urgently needed. The agendas and resolutions are in place. We do not need more words; we need action. Human rights constitute the backbone of the multilateral system and are a top priority of Cyprus’s foreign policy. Guided by our long-lasting commitment to promoting, protecting and fulfilling all human rights, as well as advancing and strengthening international human rights within the United Nations, Cyprus has announced its first-ever candidacy for the Human Rights Council for the period from 2025 to 2027, with elections taking place this fall. Our candidature is rooted in our deep dedication to promoting, protecting and fulfilling basic human rights for all, as well as advancing and strengthening international human rights within the United Nations system.

The world is at an inflection point. Our children — the generations to come — are watching, and they will hold us accountable. The decisions we make today, the courage and vision we transform into action, have the potential to change the trajectory of the world. We have an opportunity to come together and to build a safer, more secure world through multilateralism by upholding the primacy of the Charter of the United Nations. The nature of the challenges we face is such that no country can address them on its own. We need to come together — we, the peoples of the United Nations, determined.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Cyprus for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Nikos Christodoulides, President of the Republic of Cyprus, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Peter Pellegrini, President of the Slovak Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Slovak Republic.

Mr. Peter Pellegrini, President of the Slovak Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Peter Pellegrini, President of the Slovak Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Pellegrini: It is an honour and privilege to address the Assembly from this podium. It is my first time doing so in my capacity as President of Slovakia.

The United Nations Organization, which we helped to found with our brotherly Czech nation under Czechoslovakia's flag, has been here for almost eight decades. We could spend hours discussing its imperfections and flaws. We have a legitimate right to ask how the United Nations delivers on its core mission — that is, maintaining peace, guaranteeing international law and protecting human rights — and most importantly, why it fails to do so quite often.

Despite all its faults and failures, the United Nations is the only truly global forum we have. It is the backbone of the world order, based on rules and international law. The cornerstone of the world as we know it, the United Nations is a vital international ecosystem for most countries in the world, including Slovakia.

The sovereignty of the majority is — to a great extent — based on our ability to cooperate, show solidarity and look for points where our often-different interests meet. It builds on our readiness to reach a compromise and respect our diversity, based on shared universal values, rules and obligations. Especially in today's uncertain times, it is a powerful pillar of sovereignty, just like its classic features — territorial integrity or independence of action. The way we cooperate tells a story about us, where we belong, what we reach for and, eventually, who we are as people, community and humankind.

Our joint confidence in the existing system of international relations — with the United Nations as its key element — is what separates us from chaos and arbitrariness, in other words, from war and violence. There are countries and entities among us that believe that the absence of rules will be the breeding ground for their future success. They believe that force is above the law. In reality, however, the collapse of a rules-based system would eventually adversely affect those who, today, desire it the most. In Slovakia's immediate vicinity — in Ukraine — a war has been going on for almost 1,000 days as a result of Russia's aggression, which violates such basic principles of international law as sovereignty and territorial integrity. It is worth repeating that our neighbour, Ukraine, is legitimately defending itself and its people according to international law, including the Charter of the United Nations. Every day, this war continues to destroy the lives, infrastructure and future of Ukrainian men and women. Nor is it any good to for Russia's people, as they too are dying. The war has come to them as well. The escalation is growing. It is high time to start looking for a peaceful, sustainable and just end to this conflict based on the principles of international law and the United Nations Charter.

Looking at the world's geography, to certain parts of the globe it might seem like a local conflict and not the only serious conflict the world is facing today, by far. Let us recall the suffering of the people in Gaza after the horrific terrorist attack by Hamas against Israel, and the casualties on both sides, or the State collapses in Haiti and the Sudan, both of which were followed by humanitarian disasters. However, from the point of view of the international community, what we see here is an existential struggle for the nature and the future of international law and adherence

to agreed rules. None of us today can think that the United Nations can fully prevent all wars and conflicts — be they in Ukraine, the Middle East, Africa or elsewhere. The reason, however, is not some kind of alleged dysfunction of the Organization and its agencies. Rather, it is the lack of joint political will in its highest organ, the Security Council.

On the other hand, it is a fact that the United Nations was born with powerful and exclusive checks, without effective balances. For years, there has been a general understanding that the United Nations needs deep reform, and Slovakia stands ready to continue assisting that legitimate effort. We see that we must look for effective prevention management and, eventually, solutions to conflicts within local or continental alliances. The role of the United Nations remains central, but the need for partnership with regional organizations is growing. For us in Europe, it is NATO and the European Union. That is the only way for the United Nations, the foundations of which were laid in the last century, to withstand the threats and challenges of the current one.

I do not find it appropriate or useful to divide the world into a global North and global South, or an East and West. Much more important is to look at who respects our shared rules and obligations and who does not. Who is interested in making them stronger and abiding by them? Who is undermining them or applying double standards? All of us are far from perfect. However, it fills me with hope that those of us who respect our shared values and rules form the vast majority here and that those who despise, systematically ignore, harm or apply those rules only when they come in handy are but a few. It is often the same actors who try to take apart not only the rules, but also the meaning of words. In the flood of information and misinformation that we face today, we must not renounce the truth. The reverse is still the reverse and not the front. A lie is just a lie, not a fact of an alternate reality. Aggression is not defence. Occupation is not brotherly help, liberation or some mythical togetherness. Likewise, war remains war, no matter what euphemism is used. We must not forget that words and those who speak them, including in traditional and social media, remain the most powerful weapons and determiners of good and evil. They can either fortify or disrupt unity and trust in our societies and communities. They can promote tolerance or spread hatred. It is of paramount importance that we speak out against those who abuse words by giving them alternate or even opposite meanings. Promoting information integrity should be high on our priority list.

The global debate on climate change is a good example and proof that we can do that. The denial of climate change and its evidence, endorsed by renowned scientific teams around the world, quite common until recently, is now obscure even in the most marginal opinion groups, in the face of increasingly destructive climate conditions and disasters. Our emissions are already beyond the imaginary line of our commitments under the Paris Agreement, before which we could still significantly slow down what we, humankind, had caused through our activities. Blaming each other will not help either. We had better do what we can. Let us invest part of our personal and political activity into what is already happening with our climate. Mitigating the consequences of hurricanes and floods and extinguishing fires, both figuratively and, unfortunately, also literally is today's urgent climate agenda.

Freedom, human rights and human dignity for everyone must be protected. Efforts to reduce poverty and threats to food security must be undertaken. We must improve health, hygiene and vaccination standards, environmental protection, the preservation of ecosystems and diversity. Here, along with climate change mitigation, I see a huge area of action for the United Nations and its specialized agencies. Practical and well-directed policies, the coordination of various national development and assistance programmes into regional synergies and successes, as

well as comprehensive and expert evaluations of green transition efforts are what I expect from the United Nations of today.

I am proud that Slovakia belongs not only to Europe but also, globally, to the group of leaders in compliance with the joint climate commitments. I believe that the United Nations should also pay much more attention to the technological and digital aspects of our lives. Today that is almost as important as our physical identities. What I have in mind is no global regulation. That is a task for regional actors. I am thinking, rather, of the widest possible incorporation of new technologies into everything that the United Nations has been working on. My point is that the whole world should benefit more evenly from technological progress. It should become one of the main engines of social progress and the way to level differences and promote gender equality. All of that is also a part of the basic mission of the United Nations.

Another pressing problem facing many countries and the entire international community is migration. It is a phenomenon that divides rather than unites us, an agenda on which elections are won or lost today. However, we should never forget that most of our ancestors across Europe were refugees, too, when they fled before war, poverty or persecution during Nazism or communism. There is no magic formula for addressing illegal migration. It is, however, clear that many aspects of migration need clear rules, transparent procedures and effective policies, as well as measures that will help the source, transit and target countries. And it is also legitimate to appropriately address all security risks that illegal migration, in particular, brings. What we need in the first place is a calm, pragmatic and realistic dialogue leading to cooperation among all concerned parties that not only deals with the consequences but, above all, the causes of illegal migration, as well as those who aid and profit from it.

Slovakia has long been an active member of the United Nations. In the spirit of all the issues, priorities and challenges that I mentioned today, Slovakia is preparing its candidacy for a non-permanent seat in the Security Council for the period of 2028–2029. Our diplomats and experts are sitting on the executive boards of several specialized United Nations agencies. The roots of Czechoslovak — and today's Slovak — diplomacy are closely linked with international cooperation. Names like Milan Rastislav Štefánik, Štefan Osuský, Ivan Krno or Ján Papánek are well-known in the diplomatic community, and some of them left a strong footprint here in the United Nations corridors as well. The last one, Ján Papánek, was Czechoslovakia's delegate at the San Francisco Conference and was one of the 14 people who formulated the final text of the Charter that gave birth to this Organization.

All those prominent Slovak diplomats had one thing in common: they were all true and convinced multilateralists. And it is to multilateralism that we, to a large extent, owe our modern statehood and identity. It is therefore up to us, the leaders of this world, to stress in communication to our citizens that the building blocks and rules of the international community that we have been laying together for almost eight decades since 1945 have no sustainable alternative. It is our task to say and repeat that we must not bring them down but, on the contrary, fix and bolster them. Multilateralism — just like the world around us — is complex and has many diverse and often opposing layers. It requires a lot of patience, and it often brings frustration and bitterness. However, it is also the most precious generational wealth that we can relay to our posterity. It is up to us in what condition we will jointly pass multilateralism on and how well- or ill-prepared for the future it will be.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Slovak Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Peter Pellegrini, President of the Slovak Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Nangolo Mbumba, President of the Republic of Namibia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Namibia.

Mr. Nangolo Mbumba, President of the Republic of Namibia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Nangolo Mbumba, President of the Republic of Namibia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Mbumba: Namibia congratulates His Excellency Mr. Philemon Yang, President of the General Assembly. I also extend my appreciation to his predecessor, His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis, for successfully steering the Assembly through trying times. It was during the seventy-eighth session that the relevance of the Assembly's work repeatedly came to the fore through reaffirmations.

The theme of this general debate, "Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations", aligns perfectly well with our shared aspirations for effective international cooperation. In that regard, the adoption on 23 September of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) and its annexes was encouraging. Namibia is proud to have served alongside Germany as co-facilitator of the Summit of the Future. I congratulate all delegates for their commitment, which brought the Pact to fruition.

Namibia's interest in the Pact for the Future is grounded in the understanding that multilateral institutions, including the Security Council, do not represent African needs and aspirations. The institutions created in 1945 must better respond to today's challenges. At the core of the Pact is that recognition and the urgency of profound global transformation. At the heart of our quest to rebuild trust in multilateralism is a legitimate demand to be recognized as equal partners — partners who can be trusted and partners in the fight against war, poverty, global injustices and inequalities.

Namibia is particularly concerned about the impact of climate change. Changes in ocean temperatures have affected our fish stocks, with potential long-term consequences for our livelihoods, ecosystems and tourism. Namibia and the rest of the Southern African Development Community region are going through the El Niño phenomenon, which has adversely affected our food security. In that regard, Namibia had to declare a state of emergency to address the severe effects of drought.

As we approach the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, we are presented with a renewed opportunity to strengthen gender equality. Namibia remains among the top nine countries globally that have closed at least 80 per cent of the gender gap. In the past 12 months, we have achieved perfect parity in the National Assembly, in which 50 per cent of representatives are women. Namibia is preparing for the eighth presidential and national assembly elections on 27 November 2024. Political parties, including the ruling party, which I represent, have nominated female candidates. We hope that the United Nations will have a female Secretary-General in the near future.

Namibia is working to develop a sustainable energy mix to support its ambitious industrialization agenda and to contribute to the world's efforts to combat climate change. We are establishing green industrialization ecosystems for decarbonizing industries that find it difficult to lower their greenhouse emissions. Investment in those key sectors is critical, and Namibia is urging developed nations to scale up support for developing countries to facilitate gradual energy transitions.

Turning to international peace and security, there is an urgent need for the Assembly to support the modalities to actualize the advisory opinion rendered by

the International Court of Justice regarding the ongoing conflict in Gaza. Prolonged occupation does not justify or make acceptable the hardships and injustices endured. That is particularly true for the people of Gaza, who continue to be brutally massacred. As a country that has endured genocide, Namibia believes that Israel, by intent and by action, is committing genocide. Namibia continues to call for a ceasefire and for humanitarian assistance to flow unhindered into Gaza.

Economic hardships continue to affect the sister Republic of Cuba, in stark contrast to the ideals of inclusivity and the goal of leaving no one behind. Namibia calls for the end of the economic, financial and commercial blockade against Cuba and calls for the removal of Cuba from lists of States that are accused of sponsoring terrorism. Namibia also reiterates its call for the immediate and unconditional lifting of illegal sanctions against our neighbour Zimbabwe, which hinder the country's ability to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals.

A further affront to the Charter of the United Nations and its purposes and principles is the continued disenfranchisement of the people of Western Sahara, who are being denied their right to self-determination. The seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly must do more to change that situation.

In conclusion, Namibia is a child of international solidarity and, having been midwifed by the United Nations, it therefore remains its firmest of proponents. The United Nations system can be strengthened if we hold hands and work together as bridge-builders, as illustrated by the Summit of the Future. By choosing the path of collaboration over that of enmity, peaceful dialogue over war and conflict and de-escalation over escalation, we can achieve our shared goal of a more peaceful, just and prosperous world.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Namibia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Nangolo Mbumba, President of the Republic of Namibia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Mohamed Younis Menfi, President of the Presidential Council of the State of Libya

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Presidential Council of the State of Libya.

Mr. Mohamed Younis Menfi, President of the Presidential Council of the State of Libya, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Mohamed Younis Menfi, President of the Presidential Council of the State of Libya, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Menfi (*spoke in Arabic*): First of all, I am delighted to extend my sincere congratulations to you, Mr. President, on your election to the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I wish you, Sir, and your team every success.

I would also like to offer my thanks and appreciation to Mr. Denis Francis for his excellent stewardship of the previous session. I also thank the Secretary-General, Mr António Guterres, for his ongoing efforts to promote international peace and security, and for his good offices in achieving the lofty goals of the United Nations, in addition to his role in promoting human rights.

For more than a decade, Libya has endured a series of transitional phases, marked by numerous conflicts and senseless fratricidal wars. That situation has been

fuelled by foreign intervention seeking to undermine the State, deepen divisions and exert control over its natural resources and political and social decision-making. A strong stance must now be taken if control is to be reasserted. The challenges that lie ahead remain immense and complex, and we continue to strive for consensual solutions to bring parties together around one table so as to work towards a national solution. Institutional divisions ensuing from the systematic obstruction by some political parties and the resultant disputes about powers and prerogatives have, however, significantly entrenched the political and institutional crisis and further complicated the political landscape. That state of affairs started with the creation of parallel bodies, leading to the freezing of, and reneging on, commitments entered into in political agreements and the relevant Security Council resolutions, as well the exploitation of State resources as a means of exerting political pressure, exemplified most recently by attacks on the Libyan public prosecution service and the judiciary. It is therefore our duty to discharge our responsibility to make our country secure and strong when it comes to the security of our citizens and their livelihood.

Only a comprehensive political solution with financial, economic and security tracks, in addition to a national reconciliation track, is capable of unifying the institutions and fostering stability so that elections can be held, the legitimacy of all institutions can be restored and self-determination can be exercised by the Libyan people. In that context, we commend national and international efforts aimed at promoting dialogue among the various Libyan parties. It is our firm belief that the Libyan people have the right to determine their own destiny and choose who governs them and manages their affairs and resources. That will be achieved when legitimacy is reinstated and control is returned to the people — something that certain parties are doing their utmost to thwart. The Libyan people are perfectly capable of deciding their destiny and who represents them. Consulting the people through fair elections and referendums is the best way to end any political impasse.

The national reconciliation project sponsored by the Presidential Council is proceeding at a sluggish pace as a result of the recent developments in the country and attempts by some political parties to obstruct it by all means. We underscore the importance of accelerating that process so as to create trust. In that vein, we commend the efforts of the African Union. We call for a Libyan dialogue to be fostered in order to form a national pact and hold a comprehensive reconciliation conference. We underline the need for all parties to participate in a constructive manner so as to secure a peaceful settlement on the basis of a Libyan solution, free from foreign dictates and interference as lasting solutions cannot be achieved without a frank and serious dialogue among Libyans themselves, without external interference. Doing so would guarantee the unity, social cohesion and sovereignty of the country.

This month marks the first anniversary of the devastation wrought by Storm Daniel in and around the city of Derna — a painful and unforgettable event that left widespread destruction in its wake and took a heavy human and material toll. Despite the pain and the sorrow, we recall the united and concerted efforts of the Libyan people, who taught us a clear lesson about their resilience in the face of hardship and crises when they decide to resolve their issues for themselves without foreign interference or demands. We also reaffirm our support for the genuine recovery and reconstruction efforts being made throughout the country.

The crimes of genocide and ethnic cleansing being committed by the Israeli occupation against the Palestinian and Lebanese people represent a heinous violation of international law. We are committed to the principle of accountability and to combating impunity. We would point out that Libya has joined South Africa in the case it brought before the International Court of Justice regarding the Israeli entity's grave violations of international laws, resolutions and treaties, *Application of the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide in the Gaza*

Strip (South Africa v. Israel), so as to promote accountability for the violations and genocide to which the Palestinian people are being subjected. We also stress that the spectre of regional war can be eliminated by addressing the situation in Gaza and stopping the grave violations and aggressions taking place in Palestine. We affirm the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination and the establishment of their independent State, with Jerusalem as its capital.

At the regional and international levels, we stress the need for concerted efforts in combating illegal immigration and terrorism, as that issue represents a major challenge, not only for Libya but for many countries, in particular African countries and countries in the region. As a transit State, Libya bears a great burden in that regard. We believe that resolving that issue calls for concerted efforts, taking into account national legislation, humanitarian aspects and the protection of migrants' rights. As for terrorism, Libya has suffered greatly from that scourge and has been able to eliminate Da'esh thanks to the sacrifices of its people, the efforts of the military establishment and the support of the international community. We continue to work to strengthen internal security and border protection by cooperating with the international community to establish security centres to coordinate efforts among the various national security forces and neighbouring countries. The fight against terrorism is not just a military confrontation but a multifaceted phenomenon that requires concerted local and international efforts and a comprehensive approach that addresses its various dimensions. Despite the importance of the efforts of the United Nations in that regard, we believe that it is necessary to develop a national mechanism to address those challenges without any negative interference.

I say that the time has come to close ranks, build bridges of unity and make our solidarity the cornerstone of our homeland. To the generous and life-loving people of our generous homeland, I say that we have not enjoyed and nor will we enjoy our wealth and the wealth of our homeland as long as the seeds of strife and discord continue to thrive among us. Our unity is the key to our stability, and it is the hope that will carry our children towards a better future. I invite the people of Libya to maintain our national unity and to shake off external interference aimed at undermining our endeavours. History bears witness to the greatness of the Libyan people, who have inspired nations and peoples through the ages. They have shown that, despite all the challenges they have gone through, they always come back stronger, more robust and more powerful. Libyans will not forget those who stood by them in times of hardship. We will continue to work to build a bright future worthy of the aspirations and hopes of our people, and we will make all the necessary sacrifices to that end.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Presidential Council of the State of Libya for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Mohamed Younis Menfi, President of the Presidential Council of the State of Libya, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Luis Rodolfo Abinader Corona, President of the Dominican Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Dominican Republic.

Mr. Luis Rodolfo Abinader Corona, President of the Dominican Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Luis Rodolfo Abinader Corona, President of the Dominican Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Abinader Corona (*spoke in Spanish*): First of all, on behalf of the Dominican people, I would like to congratulate Mr. Philémon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session and to thank him for his work, together with the Secretary-General, on the successful organization of this session and in particular the recently concluded Summit of the Future.

That ambitious effort has emphasized the need to strengthen international financing to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and shows the sincere will to work for a present and a future of peace, citizen well-being and respect for human rights and democratic values. I want to emphasize that, in the case of the Dominican Republic, we have made considerable progress on the SDGs in terms of reducing poverty and improving food security, energy sustainability, citizen security and climate action, to mention but a few examples. As an example, monetary poverty was reduced from 25.8 per cent in 2019 to 23 per cent in 2023, despite the pandemic and the effects of the war, and in the first half of 2024, it fell to 18.9 per cent — the lowest level in our history.

Over the past four years of management, we have more than doubled expenditure on social protection. Our agricultural policy has been key to guaranteeing food security and maintaining the profitability of Dominican producers. Despite being an island with limited arable land resources, we have gone from 88.5 per cent food self-sufficiency in 2019 to 90.6 per cent in 2023. We have largely achieved self-sufficiency in the sector.

In terms of the generation, transmission and distribution of affordable and clean energy, we have made significant progress on and improvements to electricity regulations. We have begun the construction of power plants capable of generating 2,000 new thermal megawatts, with 400 megawatts already being produced, and we have contracted 1,674 megawatts of renewable energy, with 647 megawatts already being produced and power stations capable of generating 1,030 megawatts under construction. By the end of 2027, for the first time, we will have a generation surplus of more than 15 per cent, which will guarantee greater stability and sustainability and better prices for energy supply.

Citizen security has also seen a notable improvement. In 2022, the homicide rate in our country was 13.2 per 100,000 inhabitants; in 2023, it dropped to 11.5, and so far in 2024, it stands at 9.9. That index is below the average for Latin America and the Caribbean, which, according to United Nations data, is 17.2.

We maintain a firm commitment to confronting the triple planetary crisis — climate change, biodiversity loss and pollution — by playing a fundamental role in the creation of the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage and reaching the goal of 30x30 in the protection of our maritime territory. Those crucial issues require our full attention, yet the resurgence of war and rampant violence force us to focus on that unfortunate emergency. Since its adoption in 1945, the Charter of the United Nations has served us well, but after seven decades, a series of threats and challenges have accumulated that today exceed its institutional framework, as Secretary-General Guterres underscored in his opening remarks. There is a general consensus that we urgently need a new model of global governance — one that fosters greater confidence and effectiveness in the decisions emanating from this essential concert of nations.

For the Dominican Republic, a commitment to effective and renewed multilateralism is a priority. That approach is necessary to ensure respect for international law and to protect nations from global threats that compromise their security and well-being. Without concerted and principled action, the foundations of the international community will continue to weaken. Since its creation, the Dominican Republic has been a standard-bearer for peace and the peaceful

settlement of conflicts. The loss of thousands of innocent lives of children and the elderly is unacceptable. For that reason, we speak up to vigorously demand the effective protection of the civilian population, in line with the norms of international humanitarian law.

Mr. Lippwe (Federated States of Micronesia), Vice-President, took the Chair.

There is a solid theory that posits that democracies rarely go to war against one another. We Dominicans are convinced that the promotion of democracy is essential for the building of a lasting peace. Democracy cannot be reduced to a system of mechanical processes. Democracy has to be a living reality that positively transforms the lives of citizens.

We stand at a crucial juncture for democracy in Latin America and the Caribbean. Over the past few decades, we have borne witness to an alarming deterioration in the quality of and support for democratic systems. According to the recognized public opinion survey *Latinobarómetro*, support for democracy has declined significantly between 2010 and 2023, while support for authoritarianism increased over that same time period. Multiple factors have led to that decline, including the effects of frequent global economic crises, which have become cyclical since the end of the 1990s. However, another equally important factor is the fact that citizens are not seeing the tangible benefits of democracy and are very concerned about cults of personality and corruption, which undermine trust in democratic institutions.

In the light of that, a clear propensity to remain in power stands out. In the case of Latin America, that has taken the form of indefinite re-election. Over the past 30 years, that trend has burgeoned, eroding democracy. One example of that is the crisis in Venezuela, which combines a concentration of power, the persecution of the opposition and censure of the media. Without the due transparency required in any electoral process and without any supporting documentation, the crisis will only grow worse. We will continue to insist on the publication of all electoral records, their verification by impartial institutions and respect for the results of the popular will in Venezuela. Without the publication of those documents, it will not be possible to declare a legitimate victor.

Transfers of power are essential to guaranteeing a responsible and genuinely participatory political exercise. Democracy is based on a founding principle: the loser has to accept their defeat and exercise a faithful, constructive opposition. Another democratic principle establishes that the winner has an obligation to refrain from bullying or crushing their adversary. Democracy cannot be exercised solely by and for the winners; the majority has to ensure that the minority, which enjoys equal rights and must be treated equitably and justly, is respected and included.

On 19 May, the Dominican people re-elected me in the first round of elections to serve a second and final presidential mandate, also resulting in a qualified majority in both chambers of Congress. With a view to strengthening Dominican democracy, I presented to the Dominican Congress a constitutional reform that will comprehensively limit presidential re-elections to two consecutive terms and no more. That reform aims to leave a legacy of political and social stability to future generations and to establish a general principle that is clear and robust, namely, that power is always transitory and must be at the service of the people.

Every democracy needs to make a commitment to defending human rights. Doing so is fundamental to protecting dignity and the freedom of every individual and to providing legitimacy to political power. The Dominican Government is profoundly committed to protecting human rights at the national and international levels. That commitment is an integral part of our foreign policy, which establishes the promotion and defence of human rights as one of its main pillars. Here, there are neither calculations nor factions, only principles. Consequently, the crisis in Haiti

warrants particular attention. For more than three years now, the instability in our neighbouring country has put significant pressure on our own security. We have firmly been asking for the involvement of the international community to assume a leading and sustained role in stabilizing Haiti. That is a strategic need for security in my country and throughout the entire region.

The Dominican State has shouldered a high responsibility in the Haitian crisis, far beyond what should be expected of it, by providing essential services to a large population hailing from our neighbouring country. In 2023, healthcare for Haitian immigrants accounted for 12 per cent of the total medical services provided through our national health system. In addition, there are currently approximately 200,000 foreign minors in the Dominican public education system, of which an estimated 147,000 are of Haitian origin. Those figures reflect the great economic burden on the Dominican Republic and the sense of humanitarian duty it has demonstrated, but we can no longer do it alone.

After a long struggle for the adoption of various resolutions within the Security Council, we finally began to see a path towards stability emerge with the establishment of the Transitional Presidential Council and the arrival of the Multinational Security Support Mission in Haiti. We take this opportunity to express our thanks to Kenya — and President Ruto — which has provided the majority of the personnel supporting the Haitian National Police. We further thank the United States, which has shouldered most of the financial and logistical burden. Likewise, we thank Jamaica, the Bahamas and El Salvador, which have already sent their contributions. In addition, we thank the Caribbean Community for its efforts towards dialogue and cooperation in Haiti. That said, to date, only 400 of the Multinational Security Support Mission troops have been deployed, out of the minimum of 1,000 needed to ensure that the force can be effective. The resources required to fully deploy the force and achieve the goals of pacification and support for the holding, in due course, of free and fair elections have yet to be deposited in the trust fund for Haiti.

We have reached this point with great sacrifices, but practically one year ahead of the holding of elections in Haiti, conditions are still not in place for them to take place. We cannot allow the efforts that have been made to date to fall apart. If that were to happen, Haiti's collapse would be imminent, with repercussions for the entire region. This mission constitutes an exceptional source of hope for restoring normalcy in Haiti. Failure could force us to take drastic measures to protect our national security. It is unacceptable that at this stage of the game, some of the countries that have had an impact on the Haitian situation or that have committed to resolving it have not fully kept their promises. While my country's national security is at stake, I will not let up in my demands for stability in Haiti.

The Dominican Republic and the Government that I lead will continue cooperating with the international community in a supportive, committed manner to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals. The global landscape requires us to act as a cohesive community, a true concert of nations, with a common goal and vision for the future. We will be judged by history, not only for the speeches that we give in these illustrious halls, but also, more importantly, for the actions that we undertake in practice. We cannot fail our peoples. We cannot fail humankind. We cannot fail the future.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Dominican Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Luis Rodolfo Abinader Corona, President of the Dominican Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Klaus Werner Iohannis, President of Romania

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of Romania.

Mr. Klaus Werner Iohannis, President of Romania, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Klaus Werner Iohannis, President of Romania, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Iohannis: We have all gathered here, as world leaders, with the responsibility of a better global vision and the will to make it happen. There is no better or more representative framework than our 79-year-old United Nations, anchored in its Charter and international law. No matter how insecure the world is today, the answer to our problems will always be more cooperation and more solidarity. Romania will always uphold the international world order, with the United Nations at its core. If we want to find the solutions, we need to take a more responsible look at our world in order to understand its challenges. Let us remember what brought us together, here, in the first place: peace as a state of mind, as a purpose and as a tool. Regrettably, around the globe we see that insecurity, violence, conflict and even war have taken a firm grip on our world. Our main challenge is to find the much-needed solutions to restore and safeguard peace; otherwise, the international order and international law are ours to lose.

When diplomacy is the most difficult tool to use, it is precisely then that we need to use it most. Take the dire global consequences of Russia's war against Ukraine: it has unleashed the greatest security crisis in Europe in recent history, in breach of international law and with implications extending well beyond Europe. In that context, Romania has extended strong, multidimensional support for Ukraine and its people. And we are committed to maintaining it for as long as it is needed. At the same time, Romania will continue its unwavering support to consolidate the resilience of the Republic of Moldova — the country that is the second most affected by the war. Our security is not a regional matter, but a global one. That brutal war has already harmed nations and people worldwide. The issue of food security is proof of that. My country has a crucial role in facilitating grain exports from Ukraine through its ports on the Danube and the Black Sea. A long-term conflict is unacceptable, and we must stay the course. Ukraine needs the resolute support of all those States Members of the United Nations that are determined to uphold international law and the Charter of the United Nations. Romania fully supports President Zelenskyy's peace initiative, which is the only approach capable of ensuring a just and lasting peace, in full agreement with the Charter of the United Nations and international law.

Protecting all civilians must remain our common objective. Almost one year ago, the heinous attack committed by Hamas against Israeli civilians shocked the world. Amid the spiral of violence that has followed, our action based on Security Council resolutions should prevail. An end to hostilities, the safe release of all hostages and the safe delivery of humanitarian aid to civilians in Gaza are undeniable imperatives. Furthermore, we support all efforts aimed at resuming the political process on the basis of the solution of two States, coexisting in peace and security, within safe and recognized borders. More broadly, around the world, the alarm is being raised about the need to stop flagrant violations of human rights, which take many forms and have various root causes. There is a sense of urgency that remains unanswered. Conflict prevention and peacekeeping are essential tools in that regard. At the same time, we must support cooperation with regional organizations in view of their role in preventing, keeping and enforcing peace.

The impact of climate change is a growing threat to our security, and its consequences are already obvious. As those negative events increase, they impact demographics, economies, energy, connectivity and geopolitics. It is vital to further enhance international cooperation and provide much-needed civil protection mechanisms. Romania is actively participating in exercises, projects and actions at an international level to provide an emergency response, especially to limit the impact of wildfires. The United Nations system is essential to mainstreaming our efforts and to creating synergies. We need to accelerate our work to keep the target of 1.5°C alive. Since climate change is a threat multiplier, Romania supports an integrated approach to the climate-security nexus within the United Nations system. A green transition should also include an energy transition that delivers energy security as an important development marker.

We live in an era in which we could fully enjoy the opportunities offered by information, innovation and connectivity. Instead of their potential being harnessed for our common good, we see increased distrust and hatred. And we see polarization and the rise of extremism instead of coexistence and tolerance. Disinformation and the misuse of technology and other hybrid tools are at the heart of the problem and are aimed at undermining our security. In such times, it has become much easier to destroy than to build. But it is now that we need turn to global institutions, principles and values for strength. They all serve to safeguard human dignity, and human dignity cannot be secured without human rights, which are never optional but continue to stand as one of the fundamental pillars of the United Nations system. In that regard, international legal instruments have a crucial role to play. For example, in the digital transition, we see technology as a global amplifier of trends. It is up to us to decide whether it will contribute to more effective and more accessible public services.

We also have to recognize the essential role of civil society, human rights defenders and the youth in advancing human rights. We are also monitoring the situation concerning gender equality and the fight against gender violence. Romania is a firm supporter of gender equality, which we have been promoting as a member of the Human Rights Council and, most recently, as a member of the Commission on the Status of Women.

There is no viable alternative to the United Nations and its founding principles, which now remain more valid than ever. Our focus is to continue reform of the United Nations to ensure that the Organization is fit to address current and looming challenges and to deliver a more effective, more efficient and more representative United Nations in which trust can be fostered. Romania is advocating for an expanded Security Council, in which transparency and accountability are the norm, not the exception, and for a United Nations that is more accessible to the public and more meaningful, in which young people can have a say on matters affecting them, in which the voices of civil society and other stakeholders are heard. That is why the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) was so urgently required — to give fresh shape and purpose to our vision for the next generations. Finally, we see the United Nations as a continuous aspiration for a better world, from those who dreamed of peace and tolerance to those who will never stop fighting for it — a world in which sovereignty, territorial integrity, international law and human rights are respected, in which each country can choose its own path, with dignity and free from aggression, and in which every citizen is safe and free. That is our credo and our call to action.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Romania for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Klaus Werner Iohannis, President of Romania, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Félix-Antoine Tshisekedi Tshilombo, President of the Democratic Republic of the Congo

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Mr. Félix-Antoine Tshisekedi Tshilombo, President of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Félix-Antoine Tshisekedi Tshilombo, President of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Tshisekedi Tshilombo (*spoke in French*): It is with great honour that I address the General Assembly today for the first time since the people of the Democratic Republic of the Congo renewed their confidence in me by electing me for a second term at the head of our nation. Having had the opportunity to speak here in the past, I am particularly moved to be able to do so again at this significant moment for our country.

I would like to congratulate Mr. Philémon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session, just as I pay tribute to his predecessors for their constant commitment to the service of this institution.

The theme of this session, “Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations”, resonates in particular with our aspirations in the Democratic Republic of Congo.

Multilateralism and respect for a rules-based global system have been essential pillars in supporting peace, security, health and prosperity around the world for nearly 80 years. The United Nations embodies those fundamental values and remains a key player in addressing the major challenges facing humankind, from ensuring security to bringing climate change under control and fighting poverty. That reality calls for enhanced multilateral cooperation. However, the noble ideal of the drafters of the Charter of the United Nations — that of serving as an instrument through which all countries regulate their behaviour — seems to be fading. The foundation of collective security that it established is wavering. We have a responsibility to work together and to reaffirm our commitment to multilateralism, which is the key to truly transformative solutions to the challenges facing our world. As former Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld — whose sacrifice for peace in the Democratic Republic of the Congo reminds us of the gravity of our mission — so eloquently put it, “the United Nations was not created in order to bring us to heaven, but in order to save us from hell”. At this critical juncture, multilateralism is of crucial importance. It helps to respond to common threats, protect our planet and strengthen civil society and human rights.

Indeed, we cannot ignore the alarming rise in belligerent rhetoric and the indecent re-establishment of the practices of armed aggression and plundering of natural resources affecting all continents. The ongoing conflict between Russia and Ukraine that continues to affect the region is just one of the many manifestations threatening world peace. Yemen, the Sudan, Syria and the terrible tragedy taking place in the Gaza Strip are among the numerous contexts in which multilateralism would play its full role. It is imperative that we act together to take steps towards peace, sustainable development and human dignity, thereby ensuring a better future for future generations. Let us leave no one behind.

That is the clear and relevant message that inspires the theme selected to guide the work of the Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. The Pact for the Future

(resolution 79/1) and its annexes — the Global Digital Compact and the Declaration on Future Generations — which we adopted at the recent Summit for the Future, underscore the importance of active collaboration to achieve a common vision of a peaceful and prosperous future. Those documents represent a key commitment to ending conflicts, fighting extreme poverty and hunger and addressing such challenges as displacement, illegal immigration, food insecurity, pandemics and the risks of new technologies. At the same time, the Global Digital Compact stands as an essential pillar in our quest for a prosperous future, at the heart of the fourth industrial revolution, where digital technologies have become essential. That digital transformation represents an unprecedented opportunity to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030, in particular for the least developed countries. It is aimed at reducing the digital divide and integrating unconnected populations into digital services with a high social impact.

However, to meet that major challenge, inherent to the digital revolution, comprehensive reforms are needed, involving a reassessment of the international financial architecture and adequate financing. That is why the Democratic Republic of the Congo aspires to attract investment to develop connectivity in Africa and calls for cooperation from multilateral partners and telecommunications operators, with knowledge transfer being key. Indeed, support for the grid development process in our country is a promising solution to link the south and north of Africa and also to link the Indian Ocean to the Atlantic Ocean. That includes the establishment of viable partnerships as part of the Grand Inga Hydropower Project that seeks to respond to our country's growing energy demand, which has been compounded by the proliferation of connected devices.

Furthermore, it is essential to enhance the traceability of strategic minerals, which are an indispensable component of technological equipment, in order to ensure the responsible and sustainable exploitation of our resources. In addition, the full participation and commitment of youth, both boys and girls, are crucial to build a sustainable and inclusive society. That principle is the foundation of the Declaration on Future Generations (see resolution 79/1), underscoring our responsibility vis-à-vis future generations and the importance of making decisions that enable them to flourish. For Africa, youth is a major asset for Africa's future prosperity. Investing in education, particularly in science, technology, engineering and mathematics, and creating environments conducive to innovation are crucial. It is essential to address the disconnect between a rapidly growing youth population and the job market by providing the skills that they require to join the job market.

The situation in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo is particularly concerning. The resurgence of the Mouvement du 23 mars terrorist group, supported by Rwanda, has caused an unprecedented humanitarian crisis, with almost 7 million internally displaced persons. That aggression constitutes a major violation of our national sovereignty. We call upon the international community to firmly condemn those actions and to impose targeted sanctions against Rwanda for its destabilizing and damaging role. We demand the immediate and unconditional withdrawal of Rwandan troops from our territory. While recent diplomatic initiatives, such as the Luanda talks, may be encouraging, they must in no way obscure the urgency of that essential action.

The Democratic Republic of the Congo is actively working to establish lasting peace in the east of the country and to promote the economic development and social well-being of the communities devastated by this armed conflict. Nevertheless, we are not closing any door to any opportunity that would bring about that peace without compromising its sovereignty, let alone its territorial integrity. In that regard, we are resolutely committed to implementing the road map adopted as part of the Luanda process, which I firmly support and which promotes high-level dialogue with the aim

of re-establishing trust between the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Rwanda while minimizing the risk of the current security crisis devolving into a regional conflict. Moreover, my country remains open to any other initiative by our partners that would contribute to achieving this noble goal of peace.

The Democratic Republic of the Congo reaffirms its determination to ensure lasting peace. Under my leadership, we are determined to pursue the implementation of the National Programme for Disarmament, Demobilization, Community Reinsertion and Stabilization, which is a key part of our national strategy to disarm, demobilize and reintegrate combatants by providing them with viable and sustainable economic opportunities, while also stabilizing the regions affected by conflict. By ensuring the transition from the United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, we are also prioritizing the repatriation of foreign combatants. The National Programme is a crucial tool for peace in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and I invite our partners and friends to support it.

Further, thousands of victims of the genocide for economic gain in the Democratic Republic of the Congo — the genocost for short — continue to endure the devastating consequences of a past marked by violence and impunity. Recognizing and addressing the effects of that tragedy is crucial to promote the recovery and reconstruction of the affected communities. Beyond immediate humanitarian aid, a long-term approach focused on justice, reconciliation and sustainable development is vital in order to enable the victims to recover and to return to a decent life. That is why the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo decided to declare 2 August Genocost Day, which is dedicated to the victims of the heinous crimes perpetrated by rebels with the support of multinational corporations and States in the region. It is a day on which we come together as a nation, and it allows us to confront our painful past so that we can move forward. It is essential to strengthening the historical conscience of our country and to affirm our nation's determination to prevent such barbarous acts from happening again.

Terrorism is a serious threat to international peace and security, and it affects all regions of the world. Having raged in Asia, in Western Europe and in North America, this scourge now seems to be entrenching itself in Africa. As a member of the international counter-Da'esh coalition, the Democratic Republic of the Congo urges the United Nations to ramp up its efforts to implement that organization's recommendations, particularly with regard to the Aqabah process. Terrorism, which is raging in the east of our country, is closely linked to the looting and illegal exploitation of our natural resources. Those criminal activities are fuelling insecurity and financing armed groups, exacerbating conflicts in the Great Lakes region. The United Nations must therefore consider imposing severe sanctions against the persons responsible for those economic crimes in order to break that vicious cycle and to foster peace, sustainable development and human dignity for future generations.

According to the most recent voluntary national review report on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), the Democratic Republic of the Congo has made significant progress towards several of the SDG targets thanks to major reforms and interventions. Since 2019, the Government has implemented ambitious reforms to ensure free basic education, enabling more than 4 million children to attend school. Moreover, several measures have been adopted to strengthen social protection, to introduce universal health coverage, to promote gender equality and to foster the development of infrastructure and rapid industrialization via, *inter alia*, the establishment of special economic zones. Despite that progress, the global report on the Sustainable Development Goals underscores that at the current rate, the Democratic Republic of the Congo will not be able to achieve the SDGs by 2030, owing to persistent inequality and vulnerabilities, which are exacerbated by armed conflict.

In response to that challenge, a road map consisting of specific measures, initiatives and reforms has been drawn up to expedite progress and to respond to the issues contained in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Some measures have already been put in place to bring the Democratic Republic of the Congo into line with the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030. If that is to be achieved, the Democratic Republic of the Congo will need an annual investment of \$32 billion. It is therefore essential to strengthen partnerships for sustainable investment and to promote peace so as to foster stable socioeconomic development.

When it comes to the global response to the climate challenge and the promotion of renewable energy sources, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, which has already stated its commitment to ambitious action on climate, would underscore how crucial increased financial and technical support is to consolidating its efforts towards achieving the objectives of the Paris Agreement. With its wealth of biodiversity and natural resources, the Democratic Republic of the Congo sees itself as a key player in the fight against climate change. Initiatives undertaken to reduce greenhouse gas emissions are focused on four strategic sectors: agriculture, forestry, energy and waste management. Structural reforms are being introduced to reverse deforestation and to improve access to clean energy. They reflect the Government's firm commitment to preserving natural resources and a green transition.

When it comes to placing the focus on tropical forests, a major milestone was reached in Bali, Indonesia, in November 2022 with the adoption of the joint statement on cooperation on tropical forests and climate action, signed by Brazil, Indonesia and the Democratic Republic of the Congo. That stride forward reflects a collective political will to use forests as a springboard for sustainable development. The trilateral alliance for cooperation on tropical forests established on that occasion will provide a framework for tackling biodiversity issues and will offer solutions for the carbon credit markets, while ensuring that the rights of indigenous peoples are upheld.

Also, on the subject of challenges related to the environment and global warming, the second summit that the world's three main tropical forest basins — the Amazon, the Congo and the Borneo-Mekong basins — held from 26 to 28 October 2023 in Brazzaville, Republic of the Congo, must be highlighted. That African initiative, spearheaded by President Denis Sassou Nguesso, is aimed at establishing, within the framework of the United Nations Decade on the Ecosystem Restoration, the first global coalition dedicated to restoring 350 million hectares of land-based and aquatic ecosystems. Those forests form a vital defence against climate change. Given that the problems have been clearly identified and that solutions are within reach, it is crucial to take concrete action. The Amazon, Congolese and Borneo-Mekong basins are home to more than 80 per cent of tropical forests and play a crucial role in combating climate change, while providing vital ecosystem services. Improving the socioeconomic conditions of local communities, who play a key role in preserving the forests, must therefore be placed at the top of global governance priorities. For its part, the Democratic Republic of the Congo is introducing legal instruments and institutional arrangements to strengthen its position in the global carbon market. At the same time, it is open to partnerships that are in line with the Paris Agreement and its domestic legislation.

Growing awareness of the challenges posed by an unstable climate and the depletion of natural resources, which are often the root cause of armed conflict, underlines the urgent need to tackle those issues. Acknowledging the nexus between climate change, environmental degradation and security is therefore paramount to encouraging proactive action that mitigates those risks through sustainable practices. In that vein, we urge the Security Council to establish international mechanisms that incorporate climate security issues into its discussions.

The world is facing a major energy challenge. Fossil fuel-based systems are responsible for significant greenhouse gas emissions, exacerbating climate change. Without concerted efforts to promote renewable energies and, as we are already seeing, it is likely that the serious crises facing us, such as extreme weather conditions and conflicts over natural resources, will become more frequent. The Democratic Republic of the Congo has a wealth of resources, including essential minerals —cobalt, lithium, nickel and graphite, to name but a few— which can help pave the way for a sustainable energy transition. We are appealing for international cooperation in developing the necessary technologies and infrastructure. Our vision consists of making the utilization of our resources a springboard for sustainable and inclusive development, while improving education, health and infrastructure. Social inclusion is central to our strategy so as that the benefits of progress are distributed fairly. By investing in the fight against climate change and contributing to the Sustainable Development Goals, the Democratic Republic of the Congo stands ready to play a key role in transforming the world's energy systems. Together, we can build a future in which energy is clean, sustainable and accessible to all.

I would also like to address the crucial issue of gender equality. Although the equal participation of women and men in the political sphere has garnered international acceptance, there is, in practice, a persistent gap when it comes to equality before the law and the actual wielding of power. Women's concerns deserve to be factored into the major decisions affecting our society. In the Democratic Republic of Congo, we are determined to change mindsets so as to overcome the societal barriers to women fulfilling their potential. Involving men in that process is paramount so that the social dynamics are transformed and men having a role in women's success is seen as positive. The Constitution of the Democratic Republic of the Congo enshrines equality at a national level. Furthermore, the Government has introduced a strategy to combat gender-based violence, focusing on prevention, protection and reparations for victims. That strategy is reflected in the National Fund for Reparations for Victims of Conflict-related Sexual Violence and Crimes against Peace and the Security of Humankind. Draft legislation is aimed at guaranteeing that protection. It is worth highlighting the significant progress made in terms of women's participation in decision-making, with the appointment, for the first time in our history, of a woman to serve as Prime Minister and Head of Government. We are also seeing greater representation of women in Government bodies, Parliament and the judicial system. The appointment of a woman to the office of First President of the Council of State and a woman to head the Central Bank of the Congo are a case in point.

As part of that drive for progress, it is imperative that the international community, under the aegis of the United Nations, continue to support those dynamics by reinventing itself in the face of the challenges of today's world. To maintain the confidence of the international community, the United Nations must demonstrate its ability to adapt to contemporary developments and to overcome them effectively and responsibly. We must reinvigorate multilateralism through targeted reform of the Charter of the United Nations, addressing key issues, such as the Security Council, the right of the veto, Chapter VII and the use of force. However, that will not be enough. Coordination and cooperation among the various United Nations institutions and agencies must also be strengthened. Many global issues are often addressed redundantly in different forums, sometimes from contradictory angles, while other issues are neglected entirely, with each international bureaucracy seeking to defend its own existence.

In that regard, while I welcome the support of the United States, I firmly reiterate, on behalf of all African countries, the call for two permanent seats to be created on the Security Council for African countries. As the main decision-maker within the United Nations, the Council must include African representatives among

its permanent members with all the related prerogatives, including the right of veto, so as to guarantee fair geographical representation. It is a matter of justice for a continent whose role in international affairs is becoming increasingly prominent. We Africans are meeting that demand with the utmost determination.

Lastly, I cannot conclude without recalling that, after more than three decades of absence from the Security Council, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, backed by the African Union and the Southern African Development Community, has once again submitted its candidacy for the post of non-permanent member for the period 2026–2027 in the elections that are to be held in New York in June 2025. The Democratic Republic of the Congo held that position for the periods 1982–1983 and 1990–1991, when it worked to promote peace, security and stability in Africa and the world. If elected, the Democratic Republic of the Congo intends to play a proactive role in the Security Council, helping to revitalize the Charter of the United Nations and contributing constructively to the resulting debates and actions. My country therefore seeks the support of all Member States for its election.

At a time when multilateralism is being put to the test, the Democratic Republic of the Congo reaffirms its unwavering commitment to the international community and stands ready to assume with honour and responsibility the mission of forging a future in which cooperation and peace prevail over conflict and division. Nelson Mandela said that “none of us acting alone can achieve success”. We therefore call on all Member States — long-standing partners and new allies — to come together to write this crucial chapter in our collective history. Together, let us make our world a place where every nation, large or small, can thrive in dignity and security.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Democratic Republic of the Congo for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Félix-Antoine Tshisekedi Tshilombo, President of the Democratic Republic of the Congo, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Úmaro Sissoco Embaló, President of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau.

Mr. Úmaro Sissoco Embaló, President of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Úmaro Sissoco Embaló, President of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Embaló (*spoke in Portuguese; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): I would like to offer my congratulations to Mr. Philémon Yang of the Republic of Cameroon on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I wish him much success in a very complex international context. I also congratulate his predecessor, Mr. Dennis Francis, on the results he achieved during his term. To Secretary-General António Guterres, I express our acknowledgement of his deep commitment to serving our common ideals and goals in a very difficult international landscape.

The world is facing grave challenges. The obligation to follow the principles and deliver on the promises of the Charter of the United Nations is a burden that each one of us carries. We are witnessing devastating wars, the intensification of regional tensions and other grave threats to international peace and security. Hundreds of millions of people continue to live in extreme poverty, without the basic means of

subsistence, hope for a better future or human dignity. Implementing reforms in global economic and financial governance to make it more just, inclusive and equitable has become even more urgent. That is the only way to build adequate responses to the challenges facing humankind. We must fight more effectively against poverty and social exclusion through concrete action. Specifically, we must strive to finance development programmes, reduce inequalities, protect the environment and mitigate the effects of climate change.

Eight decades after the United Nations was established in 1945, we live today in a totally different world. We continue to call for the reform of the Security Council, which must consider the interests of Africa under the terms of the Ezulwini Consensus and the Sirte Declaration of the Heads of State and Government of the African Union. We must reform the international financial architecture in order to promote greater inclusion, particularly in Africa, and to consider the African continent's role in and contribution to the world economy. In that context, we welcome the Summit of the Future. We hope that the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) can drive collective efforts towards achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Agenda 2063: The Africa We Want of the African Union. As a member of the global task force on social protection for nutrition, human capital and local economic development of the Group of Seven Plus, we will work with the other members to eradicate hunger and progressively achieve all SDGs.

In the Republic of Guinea-Bissau, we are firmly committed to fostering dialogue, national reconciliation, the consolidation of democracy, the rule of law and our country's sustainable development. Despite the negative impact of the challenging world economic and financial situation, the economy of Guinea-Bissau continues to grow as a result of sound public policies. The practice of accountability has provided greater transparency in the State's economic and financial management. We have adopted measures that, although difficult, were shown to be necessary to drive the private sector and create a more solid foundation for a dynamic and inclusive economy.

We are promoting the greater participation of women and youth entrepreneurs. We are investing in building and improving basic infrastructure, such as roads, and other projects. We have declared war on corruption and organized crime. We have been able to restore trust in our relations with international financial institutions and other bilateral and multilateral partners. We continue to place faith in strengthening Guinea-Bissau's bonds of friendship and cooperation with the world. We remain steadfast in our support for the policy of peacebuilding and peaceful resolution of conflicts in West Africa and the world in general. To that end, in recent months, I made visits of friendship and work to Russia, Ukraine, Israel and Palestine. In that context, I reiterate my call for an end to the unjust and very harmful embargo to which our brothers and sisters in Cuba have been subjected for decades.

I recently had the honour of serving Africa as Chair of the African Leaders Malaria Alliance. We made significant progress in a very difficult world environment. We endeavoured to garner support to replenish the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis and Malaria. We worked with the private sector to promote the production of drugs and nets to combat malaria. We encouraged the transfer of technologies to African companies. We launched councils and funds to end malaria and supported youth movements against malaria. Despite all the progress achieved, challenges persist. In the next three years, the Alliance will run a \$1.5 billion deficit. Global warming and rains associated with climate change are expanding the geographic reach of mosquitoes, thereby exposing more than 170 million people on the African continent to the threat of malaria. I take this opportunity to congratulate the Alliance's Executive Secretary for her remarkable service. I also thank all

partners of the Alliance for their crucial support in the fight against malaria during my term in office.

In conclusion, on behalf of the people of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau and on my own behalf, I would like to reaffirm our determination to continue strengthening the friendship among countries and peoples to promote international cooperation, multilateralism, the peaceful resolution of conflict and the end of wars and the suffering of innocent populations, towards peace in the world.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Úmaro Sissoco Embaló, President of the Republic of Guinea-Bissau, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. José Maria Pereira Neves, President of the Republic of Cabo Verde

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Cabo Verde.

Mr. José Maria Pereira Neves, President of the Republic of Cabo Verde, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. José Maria Pereira Neves, President of the Republic of Cabo Verde, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Neves (*spoke in Portuguese; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): Numerous armed conflicts continue to ravage various world regions, with devastating impacts on their populations, communities and humanitarian actors, particularly in the Middle East, where the potential for escalation and risk of spillover are all too evident. Innocent lives are being lost daily in an unrelenting and merciless cycle of violence. We urge all parties involved, alongside the international community and relevant organizations, to spare no effort to put an end to those conflicts, commit to dialogue and uphold the values enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations, international law and humanitarian law, thereby allowing a gradual return to normalcy and the possibility of building a future free from the destruction and indiscriminate death of today.

At the national level, we remain committed to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals, the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Agenda 2063 of the African Union. We are also focused on implementing policies aimed at ensuring universal access to quality education and healthcare and fully integrating young people into all spheres of social, economic and political life, ensuring that future generations are equipped with the tools they need to tackle global challenges. This year, we were proud to be certified by the World Health Organization as a malaria-free country — a comforting and encouraging testament to our commitment to health and healthcare as a fundamental right for all. While many nations — in particular in Africa — are still grappling with this terrible disease, we have a unique opportunity to eradicate the preventable and treatable ailments that have long plagued humankind, causing suffering, hindering progress and trapping millions in poverty. To achieve that goal, I call on the upcoming restructuring meeting of the twenty-first replenishment round of the International Development Association Global Fund, to be held in Paris next month, to prioritize funding through a dedicated budget line aimed at eliminating diseases. Microbial pathogens and antimicrobial resistance also pose significant threats to global health. Understanding and managing microbial activity is therefore crucial for addressing challenges related to disease control, food security, environmental conservation and climate change.

In this troubled and challenging international landscape, where multiple crises continue to affect people and the planet, I reaffirm Cabo Verde's strong commitment to being an active and constructive Member of the United Nations, tirelessly championing the universal values contained in its Charter. Among those crises, climate change disproportionately affects vulnerable nations, in particular small island developing States. We look to the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change to yield urgent and tangible progress on key climate issues, particularly as the deadline for significant emissions reductions approaches. Our people, especially communities in small island developing States (SIDS), seek bolder commitments, specifically from high-emitting countries, and the swift implementation of climate policies and funding mechanisms that are not only ambitious, but also equitable and effective. Rising sea levels, which are also caused by climate change, require special attention. The challenge is multidimensional and extends far beyond island and coastal populations: it affects all continents and regions, leaving no one immune to the catastrophe in the making. We therefore welcome today's high-level meeting on addressing the existential threats posed by rising sea levels.

Last year, on the sidelines of the seventy-eighth session of the General Assembly, the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction was opened for signature, representing an international milestone in the conservation and sustainable use of marine biodiversity in areas beyond national jurisdiction, that is, on the high seas, which constitute about 60 per cent of the world's oceans. I am proud to say that my country, Cabo Verde, signed the Agreement on the first day and is currently finalizing the ratification process. I call on all nations that have not yet done so to also sign and ratify that important instrument for the conservation of life in our oceans.

Being an ocean nation, the landmass of Cabo Verde is tiny when compared to its immense maritime territory. That is why I did not hesitate to accept the honour of an invitation from UNESCO to become Patron of the Ocean Decade Alliance, as part of the United Nations Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development. As an ocean nation that is heavily dependent on marine resources, our role in the Ocean Decade focuses on local and global action to promote sustainable ocean management. We have concentrated on the importance of sustainable ocean management, in particular for small island developing States, which are very vulnerable to climate change and marine ecosystem degradation. For three consecutive years, we have hosted international ocean conferences to foster partnerships among Governments, the private sector, scientists and civil society in order to advance ocean science and create innovative solutions to ocean-related challenges. That is why it is important to bring together key stakeholders in order to boost collaborative solutions for the oceans, help develop research capacities to study the impact of climate change and ocean acidification and promote knowledge-sharing and technology transfer, with a view to improving ocean monitoring and observation systems.

The United Nations convened the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States in May, and we are delighted with its success. However, to ensure greater resilience and the sustainability of SIDS, we must begin to implement the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS as a matter of urgency. Cabo Verde remains continues to play an active role in the community of SIDS and, in the first quarter of 2025, will host a high-level meeting for the Atlantic Ocean, Indian Ocean and South China Sea regions, which will be aimed at establishing a coordination mechanism for the subregion. At the Conference, we also expressed our readiness to host the fifth International Conference on SIDS in 2034.

As small island developing States, our macroeconomic systems are facing serious problems of scale. Even if we were to allocate our entire State budget to sustainable development and climate action, it would still fall short of the necessary funding targets. In most SIDS, that situation is exacerbated by a significant lack of capacity to navigate new financial tools. While the pace of reform of the global financial architecture is slow, there is also an urgent need to accelerate development processes. We must swiftly and significantly scale up technical assistance and capacity-building efforts to finance sustainable development so as to ensure that the global South is not left behind. In that regard, we welcome the recent approval of the multidimensional vulnerability index, which is crucial, in particular for SIDS and other vulnerable groups, as it provides a comprehensive and differentiated way of assessing our development needs and challenges, thus affording a broader and more accurate understanding of how various factors influence the development of countries.

In my capacity as African Union Champion for the Preservation of Natural and Cultural Heritage in Africa and in line with the Government of Cabo Verde's policies in those areas, I have been tirelessly advocating the protection, promotion and sustainable management of Africa's rich natural and cultural heritage, which is highly vulnerable to climate change. It is essential that we continue to raise awareness of the need to safeguard our natural and cultural heritage, which includes diverse ecosystems, historical landmarks, traditional knowledge and intangible cultural practices. There is an urgent need to foster African identity through the promotion of African languages, traditional arts and the gamut of cultural expression so as to reinforce the continent's diverse cultural history and its contribution to global culture and human heritage. The restitution of cultural assets, such as artefacts, works of art and sacred objects, which are an integral part of the cultural identity, history and traditions of their communities of origin, is of vital importance — not only for Africa, but also for many other regions of the world. Their removal has disrupted cultural continuity, and their return to their original setting would safeguard their cultural and spiritual integrity and thus enable local communities to reconnect with their heritage, fostering cultural pride and preserving their identities for future generations.

I am delighted to announce that, in 2025, we will host a high-level meeting in Cabo Verde focused on the Atlantic dimension of the Creole, bringing together academics, historians, social scientists, scholars of Creole languages, artists, writers, filmmakers, men and women of culture, as well as world leaders. They will represent the plurality of geographical spaces in which the Atlantic dimension of the Creole is affirmed — a dimension in which Africans and their descendants have played an integral part in building. That 2025 meeting seeks to build on the results of projects like the Routes of Enslaved Peoples: Resistance, Liberty and Heritage and the International Decade for People of African Descent, as well as the World Conference against Racism, Racial Discrimination, Xenophobia and Related Intolerance, held in Durban in 2001. Our intention is to debate and celebrate the Creole — the Creole dimension — as a complex and very rich reality that is the product of human ties woven between peoples of the various peri-Atlantic continents during the navigation of the ocean that began in the fifteenth century. From those encounters, new forms of culture and ways of organizing society emerged and endured, marking a particularly fruitful moment of social and cultural innovation. The meeting will involve days of intense academic and scientific reflection, in addition to artistic displays, cultural exchange and reconnection encompassing the performing arts, Creole cuisine, handicrafts and music. The meeting will also offer days of political and strategic debate among decision-makers concerning the dialogue between peoples and cultures, peace and the future of humankind.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Cabo Verde for the statement he has just made.

Mr. José Maria Pereira Neves, President of the Republic of Cabo Verde, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Ms. Iris Xiomara Castro Sarmiento, President of the Republic of Honduras

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Honduras.

Ms. Iris Xiomara Castro Sarmiento, President of the Republic of Honduras, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations Her Excellency Ms. Iris Xiomara Castro Sarmiento, President of the Republic of Honduras, and to invite her to address the Assembly.

President Castro Sarmiento (*spoke in Spanish*): I stand before the Assembly as the President of Honduras, the representative of a people that has resisted oppression, exploitation and structural violence brought to bear over centuries. Today I am threatened by the same forces of capital that 15 years ago carried out a coup d'état against the President, Manuel Zelaya. I denounced this new conspiracy in the streets, in massive rallies of the people held on 14 and 15 September, the day of our national independence. I am threatened because I have pushed for structural changes to the economic model and denounced the unjust tax regime that perpetuates inequalities, feeds the powerful and exploits the poor.

Our sovereignty is the foundation and unwavering principle of our international relations, but colonial practices, interference and economic, media and political domination continue to be imposed in Honduras. The supranational Powers and certain multinational companies are the product of corrupt, public-private elites who have no other goal than to increase their capital. Globalization has failed in its mission to bring prosperity to the people. Its results show that wealth is concentrated among the richest countries and the elites, while the working class is left behind and forced to migrate in order to survive.

Before the General Assembly, the majority of Latin American and Caribbean leaders have denounced global capitalism as the main destroyer of natural resources and the enemy of decent living conditions for humankind. The accumulation of economic profits prevails over human interests, and the role of international financial organizations, with their conditional loans and fiscal and financial prescriptions, only aggravates the situation of poverty and dependence of our nations.

Neoliberal privatization policies continue to restrict people's access to water and energy services, health, education, work and social security. Free trade agreements, imposed on our peoples, infringe on sovereignty and make it impossible for our producers to compete on a level playing field, causing the cost of living to rise every day.

Peace, justice, freedom and democracy continue to be the founding values of our nation. Therefore, we cannot allow them to be hijacked by the 10 most powerful families in Honduras, who have appropriated our main economic resources and refuse to accept the changes that I am promoting. We must strengthen our democratic system through popular consultations and the real, direct participation of our people.

The international model cities project, the zones for employment and economic development, which sold our territory piecemeal as booty for multinational capital, approved by traitors in the previous narco-regime, has been definitively cancelled

by my Government of democratic socialism. Today I acknowledge the historic ruling of the Supreme Court of Justice and the support of the National Congress. I denounce the International Centre for Settlement of Investment Disputes because it is a system of unfair arbitration in which private interests prevail over the interests of nation States.

In the past two years and eight months, I approved a structural reform to rebuild a single State treasury, cancelling a corruption scheme built around trusts through which the State's resources were plundered. Thanks to the dismantling of that corrupt scheme, I am serving children in all the schools of Honduras, who now receive a daily school lunch and free tuition, and I am taking projects to communities living in extreme poverty.

We increased the production of basic grains in the first and second harvests, through more than 1.5 million technology vouchers delivered to producers who now receive free seeds and fertilizers. In addition, we promote housing and agricultural loans at the lowest interest rates in the history of Honduras, in addition to setting up rural community banks.

We are rescuing the National Electricity Company, the Honduran Institute of Agricultural Marketing and the National Commodity Supplier, which were privatized and abandoned during the 12 years and seven months of the narco-dictatorship. Today we benefit more than 800,000 families, who receive free energy, and we subsidize fuel prices to benefit all Honduran consumers with the lowest prices in Central America. The price of a gallon of fuel has dropped by 10 lempiras.

Investment in infrastructure is at its highest level in in the history of our country. We have rescued the public sector, with the historic approval of the construction of eight hospitals; the repair of thousands of schools and three national airports, the construction of highways, productive roads, bridges, intermunicipal paving and multi-sport courts for the entire country; and the restoration of the two national stadiums. And I must not neglect to mention the largest and most ambitious project in the history of Honduras, which is the plan to build the interoceanic railroad between Puerto Castilla on the Atlantic Ocean and the Port of Amapala on the Pacific Ocean.

In the past two years and eight months, we have reduced poverty by 12 percentage points. With the Solution Against Crime programme, endorsed by the Secretariat of Security with the cooperation of the armed forces, there has been a historic 15-point decrease in homicides, the largest such reduction in 20 years. My Zero Deforestation by 2030 programme has achieved historic results in the conservation of protected areas, forests and rivers in Honduras. Public funds in the Government's single treasury account are used in an honest and patriotic manner, for the benefit of the Honduran people.

I want to raise my voice to decry the murder of Honduran social and political leader Juan López, who consistently denounced the extractive exploitation model. I repudiate and condemn the vile murder, and I have ordered that the full capacity of law enforcement and the institutions of the justice system be brought to bear to investigate, identify, capture and convict the intellectual and material authors of that crime. My sympathy goes out to his family, his colleagues and his friends.

I am the President pro tempore of the Community of Latin American and Caribbean States (CELAC). We are 33 States. As President of Honduras, my first act as President of Honduras was to speak up to denounce the genocide against the Palestinian people. More than 40,000 innocent people have already been killed by a bombing that some countries have rewarded with their silence. I raise my voice from this rostrum as well to demand the end of that genocide.

Lebanon must not become another Gaza Strip. We demand an immediate ceasefire in Lebanon.

The Haitian people demand our cooperation and solidarity as an organization of Latin American and Caribbean countries. Haiti is the first nation to be liberated from colonialism. It deserves our full attention, and in the coming days, I will convene the Presidents of CELAC member countries to demonstrate our commitment.

For 30 years, the General Assembly has overwhelmingly rejected the inhumane embargo against the Cuban people. That infamous blockade began in 1960. Since 1992, the General Assembly has adopted more than 30 resolutions calling on the United States to put an end to that cruel blockade. I demand an end to the unjust blockade against the brotherly peoples of Nicaragua and Venezuela, and we demand that Cuba be removed from the list of terrorist countries.

Yesterday I submitted to Secretary-General António Guterres the agreement formalizing the support of the United Nations in the fight against corruption and impunity. I thank the General Assembly, which adopted our request to establish that mechanism against public and private corruption (see resolution 78/258). As our martyr, Berta Cáceres, a valiant woman and defender of our natural resources and our indigenous peoples, said: "Wake up, humankind!" We still have time. May that be the call of our generation.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Honduras for the statement she has just made.

Ms. Iris Xiomara Castro Sarmiento, President of the Republic of Honduras, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Joseph Nyuma Boakai, Sr., President of the Republic of Liberia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Liberia.

Mr. Joseph Nyuma Boakai Sr., President of the Republic of Liberia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Joseph Nyuma Boakai Sr., President of the Republic of Liberia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Boakai: I am honoured to address the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth regular session for the first time as President, on behalf of the Government and the people of Liberia, after a smooth back-to-back democratic transition. Liberia congratulates His Excellency Mr. Philémon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. He can be assured of Liberia's support as he steers the affairs of the General Assembly. I praise His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis for his astute leadership during his presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-eighth session and commend his determination to inspire and rekindle hope globally. I deeply thank Secretary-General António Guterres for the remarkable and visionary leadership he continues to provide in pursuit of our collective mandate.

In the summer of 1945, Liberia joined other nations in San Francisco as one of the original signatories to the Charter of the United Nations. On that momentous day, the world, having suffered the scourge of war, was full of hope and determined to reverse the past. Nearly 80 years on and reflecting on the preamble of the Charter, which declares our commitment to promoting social progress and better standards of life in larger freedom, we ask the question: Has our reaffirmation of faith in the dignity and worth of the human person, made eight decades ago, been realized? We

must admit that the world has changed and that the frontiers that we now embrace are different. Innate greed, insensitivity to the poor, the international drug epidemic, money laundering, the dynamics of climate change and the impact of social media must compel us to rethink our approach to global peace and security. Our beloved United Nations must undergo the institutional and philosophical reflection required to respond to the new age.

As we assemble under the theme “Unity in diversity, for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for everyone, everywhere”, it is important to recognize the shared values and collective efforts that come from our unity within diversity. We must acknowledge them as being essential for advancing peace, sustainable development and the inherent dignity of every human being worldwide. By doing so, we can build a better world where no one is left behind. Like many nations gathered here, Liberia recommits to the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Since the end of the country’s conflict, we have striven to follow a development path that will lead to building a capable State. Twelve years ago, we dared to dream of a future within the realm of possibility, harbouring core national aspirations to transform the future. Known as Liberia Rising or Vision 2030, it has been the driving force behind all our planning efforts. The building blocks and tenets of Vision 2030 are significantly aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals. Our Government’s ARREST Agenda for Inclusive Development is a comprehensive approach developed to address the economic and social needs of millions of Liberians, in particular young people, who account for 60 per cent of our population. With an emphasis on agriculture, roads and infrastructure development, justice and the rule of law, education, sanitation, health and tourism, the Agenda has mainstreamed the SDGs and is designed to take Liberia to the finish line of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

The fight against poverty and the promotion of human dignity are steadfast commitments. Despite our progress, poverty remains a significant challenge, with more than half of our population living below the poverty line. The Sustainable Development Goals aim to eradicate poverty in all its forms by 2030, ensure social protection for the poor and vulnerable and improve their access to essential services. Liberia is dedicated to assessing the levels and causes of poverty and to implementing strategies to reduce it and promote shared prosperity.

My Government also acknowledges the pressing need to address maternal and newborn mortality by implementing robust monitoring and evaluation of health services in the country in order to accelerate the reduction of maternal and newborn mortality. We are particularly blessed by and pleased with the United Nations H6 joint mission to Liberia this year, which concluded with a commitment to combat the high burden of increasing newborn deaths. We welcome the General Assembly’s decision to declare 25 July as the International Day of Women and Girls of African Descent (resolution 78/323). That significant milestone acknowledges that women and girls of African descent have unique opportunities and challenges and that the global fight against slavery and racism is necessary to achieve gender equality. Liberia established its credentials by producing the first woman President of the General Assembly, Mrs. Angie Brooks-Randolph, and the first female President of Africa, President Ellen Johnson Sirleaf. Liberia continues to witness the immense contributions of women and girls of African descent to politics, culture and every area of societal development.

Liberia has enjoyed uninterrupted peace for almost two decades, following 14 years of civil conflict. During that time, we have held four democratic elections, with last year’s election marking the fourth since the return to democratic order in 2006. In January 2024, Liberia achieved a historic milestone by peacefully transitioning

from one democratic Government to another. That progress is significant because, before the 2018 transition, the previous democratic transition occurred in 1944, about 74 years earlier. We are gradually fostering and solidifying our democratic culture, ensuring that democracy is here to stay in Liberia. Now it is time for our people to reap the democratic dividends. The rule of law is fundamental for peace, justice, strong institutions and dignity for the human person. Liberia is taking significant strides toward openness, transparency and accountability by empowering and supporting transparent institutions. Our Government is committed to implementing audit recommendations by the General Auditing Commission to restore public and donors' confidence in the governance system and to improve regional and international cooperation.

In addition, the country has taken a major step in confronting its conflict-marked past in order to ensure accountability and justice for crimes and other human rights violations committed during the war and to promote healing and national reconciliation. A significant development in our transitional justice process was the signing, on 2 May 2024, of Executive Order 131 to create an office for the establishment of a war and economic crimes court for Liberia — a key recommendation from the truth and reconciliation process in Liberia.

Our actions align with the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights and the joint follow-up report on impunity and past human rights violations. As we embark on that process and acknowledge the enormity of that task, my Government seeks the support of the United Nations, partners and stakeholders in the pursuit of justice for victims, as well as peace and reconciliation.

Liberia is facing a drug crisis that is affecting our youth and jeopardizing the country's future. That epidemic, driven by international criminal enterprises and their networks, poses a severe threat. In response, we have not only declared the drug epidemic a health emergency and a national security threat, but we have also taken steps to address the issue by establishing a dedicated national body to tackle drug abuse in Liberia. I urge the international community to join Liberia in addressing the escalating drug crisis.

The world is facing numerous crises, including global threats such as disease, insecurity and climate change, as well as food and resource shortages. Our vulnerabilities are evident, and we need to use our collective knowledge to find solutions that will preserve the planet for future generations. Climate change is undeniably real and its threat to our environment and way of life is becoming increasingly apparent. We must take urgent action to address that threat, including through cooperative efforts to implement article 6, paragraph 2, of the Paris Agreement.

As the most forested country in West Africa, with over half of its land covered by forests, Liberia plays a vital role in biodiversity and environmental sustainability. As a result, our country is taking important steps to lead the conversation on climate action. My Government has called on our legislature and other stakeholders to begin looking at the Paris Agreement, particularly under article 6, to help advance actions towards establishing Liberia's nationally determined contribution to combat climate change. While we take those actions, we are mindful of the need to build capacity and invest in critical areas of our economy, such as by using alternative financing to invest in the blue and green economy and using technological transfer to support climate action.

The goals we set for ourselves and for the future are better served on the foundation of peace and security. Having enjoyed peace for over two decades following a long-running conflict, we aim to promote peace and stability at home, in the region and globally. The threat of conflict to our shared world underscores the

importance of collaborative efforts to foster regional and global stability and peace. Therefore, we support all efforts by the United Nations to address peace and security issues worldwide.

Liberia is concerned about the escalating security challenges in the West African region, including terrorism and economic and political instability. Those issues pose a significant threat to regional peace. We therefore make an urgent call for full dialogue and cooperation among West African nations in order to address those issues effectively. Meanwhile, Liberia stands firmly with the rest of West Africa in our resolve to keep our 50-year-old regional economic commission — the Economic Community of West African States — intact. We oppose efforts to disintegrate our union and will not accept the region being used for proxy conflicts. We look to the African Union and the United Nations to support us in keeping the regional body united.

Similarly, at the global level, we call for an immediate ceasefire in the Middle East so that we can provide civilians with essential humanitarian relief. We urge both Israel and the Palestinians to engage in negotiations towards lasting peace, including a two-State solution.

Additionally, we see the ongoing conflict in Ukraine as a threat to global peace and security. As such, there is an urgent need for a peaceful resolution that also respects Ukraine's territorial integrity.

This year's session of the General Assembly is a pivotal moment for Liberia's bid to ascend to the African non-permanent seat of the Security Council in 2026. As we proudly announce our candidacy, we look forward to the support of Member States to vote overwhelmingly in favour of Liberia's election to a non-permanent seat on the Security Council, where we can work with Council members to promote peace and security and justice.

Liberia is dedicated to promoting sustainable growth and ensuring human dignity for all. Liberia is prepared to work together with the United Nations, other global allies and the international community to realize the Sustainable Development Goals and establish a fair, peaceful and sustainable world. That commitment to unity is deeply ingrained in Liberia's history as a founding member of the United Nations and other post-war international institutions, as well as regional and subregional organizations. It also affirms our strong belief in multilateralism and an international rules-based world order built on shared values and principles crucial to our future. The future of a more peaceful, prosperous and sustainable world must be all-encompassing, fair and dignified for everyone worldwide — one United Nations, one world.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Liberia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Joseph Nyuma Boakai, President of the Republic of Liberia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Mokgweetsi Eric Keabetswe Masisi, President of the Republic of Botswana

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Botswana.

Mr. Mokgweetsi Eric Keabetswe Masisi, President of the Republic of Botswana, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Mokgweetsi Eric Keabetswe

Masisi, President of the Republic of Botswana, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Masisi: I wish to start by extending my congratulations to Mr. Philémon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. He can be assured of Botswana's full support as he steers the work of this organ.

The Assembly continues to meet against the backdrop of an age of multiple and interconnected crises triggered by the coronavirus disease pandemic and geopolitical tensions between major Powers. Those crises have been further compounded by the Israel-Hamas war, which erupted shortly after we concluded last year's high-level week. The attacks on innocent civilians on both sides are unacceptable and, therefore, stand condemned. In the same vein, we wish to express our deep concern about the situation in the Gaza Strip, where the war has resulted in catastrophic humanitarian crises and unprecedented fatalities among civilians, including children and humanitarian workers.

I should also register Botswana's concern regarding the loss of lives of United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) personnel. I take this opportunity to pay tribute to UNRWA personnel and all humanitarian workers and their commitment to deliver aid, save lives and alleviate suffering in Gaza and elsewhere. We owe them a debt of gratitude, and they deserve our full protection. Botswana also abhors attacks on UNRWA installations and condemns disinformation and misinformation campaigns against that life-saving, General Assembly-mandated Agency.

Botswana firmly supports the work of UNRWA, which entails providing humanitarian and development assistance and protection to Palestinian refugees, pending the just resolution of the Palestinian question. In that regard, Botswana is proud to be among the countries that joined the statement of shared commitments on UNRWA, which reaffirms support for the Agency, its mandate and its staff and highlights its indispensable role during this difficult time.

We wish to reiterate the centrality of the two-State solution in resolving the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and the attainment of a just, comprehensive and lasting peace. We therefore urge parties to commit to a political process that will pave the way for the realization of the two-State solution, wherein Palestine and Israel live side by side in peace and security based on the pre-1967 borders.

The war in Ukraine also rages on, with no indication of an end in sight. We continue to underscore the need to respect the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Ukraine, in line with the Charter of the United Nations and international law. We also call on parties to give diplomacy and dialogue a chance and to seek a peaceful resolution.

In Africa, the guns have still not gone silent. We continue to grapple with armed conflict, terrorism and potentially explosive geopolitical tensions. We commend the African Union (AU) and subregional bodies, as well as the United Nations, for their efforts in addressing those challenges. In that vein, we welcome the adoption of Security Council resolution 2719 (2023), on the provision of support by the United Nations to AU-led peace support operations on a case-by-case basis, and look forward to its operationalization.

I must add that this time of escalated armed conflicts, violent crime and humanitarian crises requires intensified efforts and more vigilance to protect human rights, advance humanitarian action and promote accountability in line with the United Nations Charter, international law and international humanitarian law, as well as relevant principles, such as the responsibility to protect.

It is evident that peace is under strain across the world. It needs to be revitalized. However, that task cannot be left only to multilateral and regional bodies. Governments have a responsibility to create conditions that enable peace to thrive within their countries. Key steps that Governments should take include building effective institutions, committing to good governance, protecting human rights and upholding democratic values.

As many are aware, Botswana has a long track record of commitment to those democratic principles. The implementation of recommendations from our recently concluded constitutional review process, as well as our upcoming general elections, on 30 October 2024, provide opportunities to deepen our democracy and strengthen our good governance credentials.

Regrettably, as the scourge of war rages on, the promise of sustainable development is in great peril. It is deeply concerning that, with only six years before the 2030 deadline, the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are way off track. We learned from the *Sustainable Development Goals Report 2024* that only 17 per cent of the Goals are on track, while the rest range from moderate progress to stagnation and, even, regression.

There is a lot of work to do. We must take inspiration from and build on the success achieved in the reduction in global child mortality, the prevention of HIV infections, the attainment of girls' parity with boys in education and increased access to energy and to the Internet, while also scaling up action and investments in areas that are lagging far behind, particularly poverty eradication. The levels of extreme poverty remain disturbingly high, and we cannot attain sustainable development without eradicating poverty in all its forms and manifestations. Poverty eradication is the sine qua non of sustainable development.

A comprehensive approach will be required to move the needle in the fight against poverty. We therefore endorse the call for comprehensive social protection systems and inclusive economic policies. Pro-poor policies should also be complemented and reinforced by policies that spur inclusive economic growth and create sustainable employment. Policy interventions that are aimed at leaving no one behind ought to be matched by adequate SDG financing. In that vein, my delegation reiterates the call for predictable, sustainable and sufficient development financing to developing countries from all funding sources.

In addition to livelihood issues, progress should also be accelerated in addressing other forms of inequality within countries, especially gender inequality. Meaningful action is needed to empower women and girls in areas where they are left behind and to combat harmful cultural practices and gender-based violence.

Extreme weather events and related natural disasters continue to remind us of the severity of the climate crisis and the urgency of mitigation and adaptation. In our subregion, Southern Africa, the El Niño phenomenon induced drought and floods that resulted in devastating consequences for livelihoods and a humanitarian situation that affected more than 61 million people. I take this opportunity to reiterate the importance of the Southern African Development Community's regional humanitarian appeal of at least \$5.5 billion, aimed at augmenting domestic resources of the affected Member States, including efforts for resource mobilization from national, regional and international partners in response to the effects of El Niño-induced droughts and floods.

I cannot overemphasize the need for adequate climate financing for effective climate action. We continue to remind developed countries of their annual \$100 billion commitment in climate financing for developing countries until 2025 and call for a more ambitious goal thereafter.

Efforts towards attaining sustainable development ought to be redoubled in countries in special situations, in particular small island developing States, least developed countries and landlocked developing countries (LLDCs), which are disproportionately affected by development challenges.

Botswana, as an LLDC and current Chair of the Group of Landlocked Developing Countries at the United Nations, is deeply concerned about the enormity of the challenges faced by LLDCs in their effort to implement the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and its SDGs. With no direct territorial access to the sea, LLDCs struggle with international trade, connectivity and economic development. Our countries are cut off from the global marketplace and lack the means to develop adequate transport and logistics infrastructure, and therefore inevitably face significant challenges in achieving the Sustainable Development Goals.

The forthcoming third United Nations Conference on Landlocked Developing Countries, which will take place from 10–13 December 2024 in Gaborone, under the theme “Driving progress through partnerships”, will provide an opportunity to effectively address those challenges in an ambitious, action-oriented and forward-looking programme of action. I therefore invite transit countries, development partners and other stakeholders to join us in the beautiful and vibrant Gaborone as we shape the future for our 32 member countries.

As the President of the General Assembly rightly observes, it is only when we act together that we can effectively deliver meaningful progress for people, for the planet and for prosperity and peace while leaving no one behind. Without a doubt, the United Nations-led multilateral system remains an indispensable platform for the effective global action that this moment demands. It is therefore of paramount importance that the multilateral framework remain fit for purpose.

The onus is on us, as Member States, to ensure that our intergovernmental processes enable, rather than stifle, effective multilateral action and international cooperation. We must not allow the current geopolitical tensions and great Power rivalries to get in the way of progress. Our shared values, norms and interests as expressed in the Charter of the United Nations, the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and other relevant frameworks should remain the North Star guiding our engagements. The spirit of consensus and solidarity ought to be at the front and centre of our actions.

Allow me to conclude by reaffirming Botswana’s commitment to working constructively on all agenda items before the General Assembly during this session. The session offers opportunities to turbocharge action for peace, sustainable development and human rights for the benefit of present and future generations. Let us seize the moment.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Botswana for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Mokgweetsi Eric Keabetswe Masisi, President of the Republic of Botswana, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Emmanuel Macron, President of the French Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the French Republic.

Mr. Emmanuel Macron, President of the French Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Emmanuel Macron, President of the French Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Macron (*spoke in French*): I speak here on behalf of a country that will never forget what nations are capable of when they unite: freedom — France has just paid tribute this year to the peoples of America, Europe, Africa, Asia and Oceania who enabled it to free itself from the Nazis' grip eight decades ago — progress and peace. Once liberated, France and its peoples founded a community of free and sovereign States, capable of committing themselves to each other and agreeing on the essentials. Also, hope, and we saw that again recently during the Olympic and Paralympic Games hosted by France this summer in the beauty, enthusiasm and harmony of peoples.

And yet despite that jubilation, the Olympic truce — called for unanimously in this very Hall — has never come to fruition. And yet the danger of empty words and impotent diplomacy lies before us every day. And yet our Organization is facing the greatest convergence of crises in its eight decades of existence, and there is a growing sense of a loss of control in the face of war, climate change and growing inequality and injustice. Every day, humankind seems to fragment further, at a time when the circumstances demand strong and effective collective responses.

To restore to those two words — United Nations — their power to inspire hope, we must come together, as we once did, atop a crucial foundation. And that is what I would like to say a few words about.

First and foremost, we must restore the terms of trust and respect among peoples, which I can see fading away in the debates we are holding. To do so, we must show equal concern for those who suffer. I spoke of this here two years ago (see A/77/PV.4), when I warned of the possibility of a double standard. A life is a life. The protection of civilians is an imperative standard and must remain our North Star, even as we celebrate the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Geneva Conventions this year. Let us not for a single moment entertain the idea that the deaths in Ukraine are those of the North, that the deaths in Gaza are those of the South or that the deaths in the conflicts in the Sudan, the Great Lakes region and Burma are those of consciences that are all too alone in their indignation.

Regaining control and restoring trust therefore entails a universal quest for peace, refusing to accept any differences whenever the dignity of human life or the territorial integrity or sovereignty of States is at stake. The conflicts we face today call into question our very ability to ensure respect for our Charter of the United Nations. And when I see certain parties wanting to propose peace by demanding capitulation, I am astonished that anyone could support such an idea.

I wish to reiterate here how vital the protection of civilians, all humanitarian workers and all those who work to uphold our shared values is in every one of those conflicts.

We must find a collective response to the major challenges posed by the two wars affecting Europe and the Middle East.

In Ukraine, Russia is waging a war of territorial conquest in defiance of the most fundamental principles of international life. It is guilty of serious breaches of law, ethics and even honour. None of Russia's actions correspond to the common interest of nations, nor to the particular responsibilities it assumes in this Organization. Ukraine's fate affects peace and security in Europe and throughout the world. For who would still believe that we are protected from our strongest, most violent and greediest neighbours if we let Russia prevail as though nothing had happened? No one.

It is therefore in our common interest — in the common interest of all nations — that Ukraine's legitimate rights be restored as swiftly as possible and to build a just and lasting peace. France will continue to do everything in its power to ensure that Ukraine stands firm, removes itself from danger and obtains justice. France will continue to supply Ukraine with the equipment it needs to defend itself and, together with its closest allies and partners, will support the remarkable resistance of the Ukrainian people and work to ensure their lasting security. Let us seek peace. France will join forces with all sincere partners to build a solid peace for Ukraine and for Europe.

I know that for many Member States, the most important issues are elsewhere: in the all-too-long list of forgotten wars, unjust victories and poorly negotiated or sometimes never implemented resolutions. I have not forgotten any of them, even if I cannot mention them all here. President Tshisekedi Tshilombo preceded me at this rostrum a few moments ago. I will be visiting the Great Lakes region with him and with President Kagame in a few days' time, as the situation there is of great concern to us. France also stands firmly by Armenia's side, together with Prime Minister Pashinyan, in the face of pressure from Azerbaijan and territorial tensions. The international community must be there to ensure that peace negotiations succeed and that internationally recognized borders are preserved.

But I know that for many Member States — and for us, too — the essential issue beyond those wars, is the situation today in Gaza, where the fate of the Palestinian people weighs heavily on each of our debates. With regard to such a complex subject, I wish to reiterate France's position from day one with the utmost clarity. We firmly condemn the terrible and unprecedented terrorist attack carried out by Hamas against Israel on 7 October 2023. Terrorism is unacceptable, regardless of its causes, and we mourn the victims of the Hamas attack on 7 October, including 48 French citizens. My thoughts of compassion and friendship go out to all the families living with the pain of having lost children, relatives or friends on 7 October. We also solemnly call once again for the hostages to be released. Several of our French compatriots remain among them. I also wish to commend the efforts of the United States of America, Egypt and Qatar to achieve the hostages' release, which remains a priority for us all.

In the face of that terrorist attack, Israel has a legitimate right to protect its own people and to deny Hamas the means to attack again. None of us would have suffered the blows of 7 October without drawing consequences. Nonetheless, Israel's war on Gaza has gone on far too long. There is no justification nor explanation for the tens of thousands of Palestinian civilian victims. Too many innocent people have died, and we, too, mourn their loss. Their deaths represent a scandal for humankind and a dangerous source of hatred and resentment that does and will threaten the security of all, including of Israel tomorrow.

The war must therefore be brought to an end and a ceasefire implemented as soon as possible. At the same time, the hostages must be freed, and massive-scale humanitarian aid must be delivered to Gaza. We have held that position since October 2023, pushing for resolutions with many Member States and holding the first humanitarian conference for Gaza in Paris in November 2023. Today it is a question of political will, given the destruction of Hamas's military capabilities. It is imperative that a new phase begin in Gaza, that the weapons fall silent, that humanitarians return and that civilian populations finally be protected.

France will take part in any initiative that saves lives and ensures security for all. The deployment of an international mission must pave the way for the implementation of the two-State solution. It is up to the Security Council to decide on that, and the necessary steps must be taken without further delay to preserve the link between Gaza and the West Bank, to restore the Palestinian Authority to its functions, to

ensure the reconstruction of the territory and, quite simply, to make life possible once again.

France will do everything in its power to ensure that the Palestinians finally have a State, living side by side with Israel. The conditions for a just and lasting peace are well known — all that remains is to pave the way, which must be as direct as possible. France will therefore draw the consequences of its commitment to the two-State solution and renew its action to ensure that such a solution finally comes to fruition for the benefit of the peoples, to meet their legitimate aspirations, to bring about a Palestinian State, to provide Israel with all the necessary guarantees for its security and to build mutual recognition and common security guarantees for all in the region. We will be working on that over the coming weeks with Israelis and Palestinians and with all our regional and international partners.

For the time being, as we speak, the main risk is that of escalation. My thoughts are with brotherly Lebanon and the Lebanese people. For too long, Hizbullah has been running the unbearable risk of dragging Lebanon into war. Israel, for its part, cannot extend its operations into Lebanon without consequences. France demands that everyone respect their obligations along the Blue Line. We will therefore act to bring about a diplomatic solution, which is essential to spare the civilian population and prevent a regional explosion. There must not and cannot be a war in Lebanon.

Therefore, we firmly call on Israel to stop escalating in Lebanon and on Hezbollah to stop firing into Israel. We firmly call on all those who provide them with the means to do so to desist. We have asked for the Security Council to meet today for that purpose, which I welcome. The French Foreign Minister will be visiting Lebanon this weekend.

Such is the unity we must demonstrate in the face of the major regional and global challenges we face. Beyond the conflicts we are experiencing that I have just mentioned, we must continue to work together to ensure respect for each other's sovereignty and build regional and international solutions to those challenges.

That is the essence of the relationship we want with Africa — a new partnership on which we have been working for the past two years. France has done a great deal for the African continent in recent years and decades — particularly in the Sahel, where French armies have successfully fought terrorism side by side with their regional and international partners. Nevertheless, military coups in the region have led us to draw legitimate conclusions.

But Europe and Africa share a common destiny, which calls for a broad partnership for peace and security, which means renewing its terms with more training, more equipment and greater mutual respect. Such a partnership is also based on the economy, energy, sport, culture and remembrance. That is what we have patiently built with Benin, Senegal, Cameroon, Algeria, Morocco and many other countries in recent years, and we will continue to implement it.

That same philosophy has, for six years now, led us to build an unprecedented partnership with the Indo-Pacific, where France's ambition is to contribute to respect for international law, without which there can be no prosperity. Some in that region, which has experienced exceptional growth in recent decades, are tempted to break the rules or even impose their will by force. France is proposing an alternative — not to take the place of anyone else, but to give the States of the region back the possibility of choosing their partners, project by project. France's Indo-Pacific territories have unique expertise in combating climate change, protecting biodiversity, developing clean energies and countering transnational threats. Our vocation in that respect in the region is to better cooperate with everyone, in their environment. As is evident, that logic of partnership is aimed at building new balances, rejecting the

fragmentation of the world and old patterns and instead seeking, in a spirit of mutual respect, to build paths to stability and peace.

Beyond that, the challenge we face — of course, impacted as we are by the conflicts I just mentioned — is keeping track of our multilateral agenda and holding steadfastly to the effectiveness to which we are committed. After having lived through the coronavirus disease pandemic, which so forcefully reminded us of the importance of some of those common challenges, we must not forget the need to pursue that track. I firmly believe that effective multilateralism has never been as necessary as it is today, and it must lead to results in terms of development and the fight against inequalities in education, health, climate, biodiversity and technology. With regard to each of those pillars, we need unity. Here, too, we need to do everything we can to avoid the divide between North and South. That is exactly the philosophy we developed in the Paris Pact for People and the Planet, which more than 60 countries have now joined.

First of all, we must ensure that we never force any State to choose between its objectives. Why should States in the North lecture States in the South about respecting the climate and therefore forgoing economic opportunities — that they should do what some States in the North failed to do 40, 30 or even 20 years ago? It is unacceptable and unintelligible. Therefore, we need to build an agenda that simultaneously advances the fight against inequality and economic development in favour of education, the climate and biodiversity and global health.

Solutions must be developed and based on proposals from the countries themselves. That is what we have begun to build, for example, with our partnerships for just energy transitions. We cannot implement a single solution for everyone, nor hand down lessons from our capitals whereby, in one way or another, we come to inspect countries and ask them all to follow the same recipe. Each country has its own unique path — that is the key to sovereignty.

Then all we need is a public financial shock and additional private leverage. That is what enabled us, three years ago, to support and work towards increasing the International Monetary Fund's special drawing rights and to obtain the effective reallocation of almost 100 billion special drawing rights to those countries that need them most, particularly in Africa. It is a silent but indispensable revolution. That is also why, thanks to the strength of the Paris Pact — several members of which we were just with — under the effective authority of President Macky Sall and with the support of the United Nations, the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development and other organizations concerned, we want to pursue that cycle of reforms and carry out a profound transformation of the multilateral banks and our financial institutions.

We have launched the objective of Finance in Common, bringing together development banks from all over the world, including those whose agendas are not aligned. We need to work on that common financial agenda if we are to meet the objectives I mentioned. In the coming months, we need to work — together, I hope — to thoroughly reform the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund. First and foremost, we must renew their membership, as those institutions were conceived at a time when many of the States here were not independent.

The capital structure must be renewed in order to strengthen it. The World Bank and the International Monetary Fund were conceived, designed and calibrated at a time when the challenges were not the same, when the global economy was not the same size and when demographics had nothing to do with it. We need to remove absurd taboos — obstructions sometimes imposed by the biggest players who prevent others from putting money in for fear of being diluted. We need to give

those institutions the capacity to act and to finance the projects that the countries of the South need.

Such a reform is imperative for our collective credibility. I wish to tell the richest countries and those who, alongside France, have a seat at the table that, should they decide not to do it, they will see an alternative order emerge in the years to come. It will come from others who do not share their agenda. Should they decide not to do it, they will be condemned and accused of cynicism — and perhaps not wrongly so.

That reform of financial multilateralism is essential if we are to meet those challenges. We also need to pursue our climate and biodiversity agenda. The forthcoming Conferences of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change are important meetings, and France will fully play its part, in particular by organizing a major meeting on the oceans for the United Nations, in conjunction with Costa Rica. Indeed, in June 2025, Nice will host the United Nations Ocean Conference, and we will be continuing our work on the process. I hope that many Member States will be able to ratify the achievements of the past few months in that respect, in particular the much-needed Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction. We are also continuing to make progress on the vital issue of water, with the new One Water Summit to be held in partnership with Kazakhstan and Saudi Arabia. I will not go into all the necessary subjects here.

But I would also like to remind representatives that artificial intelligence requires all Member States present here today to coordinate their efforts. We need to encourage innovation. We need to ensure that innovation in artificial intelligence is accessible to all the countries and peoples of the planet and that it does not fuel new divides and inequalities. But we need all of that to develop within a united ethical and democratic framework, designed by the peoples of the planet. We cannot let a few people — let alone private players, who are currently at the forefront of such innovations — think up their future for us and our peoples. That is why France will be hosting the next Artificial Intelligence Action Summit in February 2025. As is evident, the aim is to build a common framework, and I am delighted with the work that has been carried out and coordinated by the Secretary-General, including on the Global Digital Compact, which was drawn up with the best experts and fully embodies the philosophy to which we are committed.

To conclude my remarks, and aware that I have neglected to mention so many difficult situations — from Venezuela to the heart of Africa, as well as so many oceans-related tensions — I would like to conclude by talking about our institutions. I hear a lot of people saying that the United Nations should be scrapped, that it is no longer useful and that it clearly cannot resolve conflicts.

Let us be constructively impatient. Let us be impatient; I share that impatience with you. We cannot be satisfied with not knowing how to settle things. But let us be clear: those responsible are here. As long as we have a Security Council that is blocked, so to speak, in a reciprocal manner dependent on the interests of each side, it will be difficult to move forward. Is there a better system? I do not believe so. Therefore, let us simply make the United Nations more effective, first and foremost by making it more representative.

That is why I reaffirm France's position in favour of enlarging the Security Council. Germany, Japan, India and Brazil should become permanent members, as should two countries designated by Africa to represent the continent. New elected members should also be admitted. But reforming the composition of the Security Council alone would not be enough to restore its effectiveness. I therefore hope that such a reform will also enable us to change our working methods, to limit the right

of veto in cases of mass atrocities and to focus on the operational decisions required to maintain international peace and security. That is what we must have the courage and the audacity to do, and it is what we, along with the other current permanent members, must carry forward.

Nearly 25 years after the Millennium Summit, the time has come to regain our effectiveness so that we can take more effective action in the field with States and civil society alike. Beyond the United Nations, we need to usher in a new era in each of our multilateral institutions, as I have just mentioned.

Those are the few words I wanted to address to the Assembly today. At a grave moment in our international order, when so many conflicts seem unresolvable, I want to say that France will continue to try to advance along that demanding path, faithful to its values, refusing the simplifications of the moment. We will continue to fight for the simple principles that have always carried us forward, namely, human dignity and respect for the principles of the Charter of the United Nations, which, beyond conflicts and current events, has a vocation to continue to build with Member States a fairer and more effective international order. Such will be our voice, always spoken as one, side by side with our friends and allies, but also free at times to say no and to refuse the cynicism of the moment or foregone conclusions that are no longer such.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the French Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Emmanuel Macron, President of the French Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

The meeting rose at 2.30 p.m.